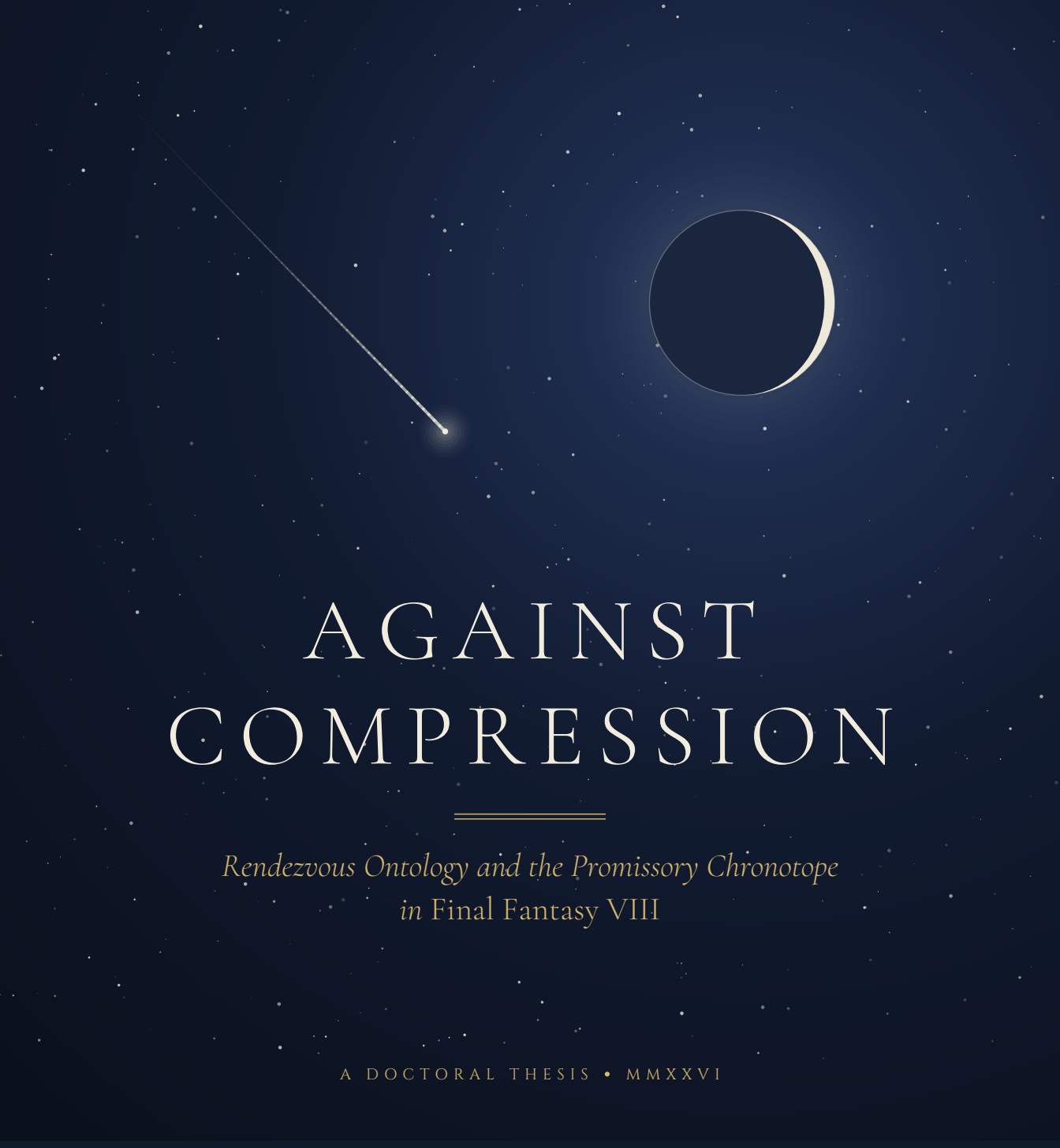


AGAINST COMPRESSION

Rendezvous Ontology and the Promissory Chronotope in Final Fantasy VIII

A DOCTORAL THESIS • MMXXVI



Abstract

THIS thesis proposes a new interpretive framework, *rendezvous ontology*, through an exhaustive philosophical reading of *Final Fantasy VIII* (Square, 1999), directed by Yoshinori Kitase, written by Kazushige Nojima, and built upon a systems architecture credited to Hiroyuki Ito. It argues that the game is a rigorous, if unsystematic, philosophical machine for thinking subjectivity under three conditions of dispossession, each rendered simultaneously as narrative event and as procedural rule. *Mnemonic dispossession* is encoded in the Junction system, whose Guardian Forces confer power at the price of memory and thereby literalize the Platonic *pharmakon* as Derrida and Stiegler reconstruct it. *Genealogical dispossession* is encoded in the bootstrap structure by which SeeD is founded on information delivered from its own future, and by which sorceress power circulates through a succession of witches that possesses no originating term: an inheritance without testator that realizes, at the level of plot, what Derrida called the "fabulous retroactivity" of every foundation. *Chronological dispossession* is encoded in Ultimecia's project of Time Compression, reconstructed here as the convergence of four discourses: the scholastic definition of eternity as *tota simul* possession (Boethius), the Hesiodic figure of Kronos devouring his children, the late-twentieth-century political economy of time-space compression (Harvey, Jameson, Virilio), and the metaphysics of presence pursued to its terminal catastrophe. Beneath all three runs a single systemic logic, which the thesis names the *general economy of convertibility*: magic is drawn, stocked, refined and junctioned; cards become items; experience becomes a parameter; persons become rank and salary; and time itself becomes a single exchangeable instant.

Against this economy the game posits a remainder that cannot be converted: a promise made at a place. Through close reading of the final sequence, in which Squall Leonhart, stripped of memory and unable to recall the face of Rinoa Heartilly, survives the dissolution of chronology by holding to the flower field where he had promised to wait, and is there *found* rather than self-recovered, the thesis formalizes rendezvous ontology in three claims. First, identity under mnemonic dispossession is secured neither by memory (Locke), nor by narrative sameness (Ricoeur's *idem*), nor by resolute being-toward-death (Heidegger), but by a promise whose fidelity is held in trust by another: *deposited ipseity*. Second, such a promise binds not a time but a place, generating a *promissory chronotope* in which temporal boundaries soften without collapsing, a figure assembled from Bakhtin's idyll, Nishida Kitarō's *basho*, Ernst Bloch's *Heimat*, and Watsuji Tetsurō's spatial correction of Heidegger. Third, every rendezvous is asymmetric, requiring one who abides and one who seeks; by assigning abiding to the knight and seeking to the sorceress, the game inverts the Homeric topology of fidelity, in which Penelope keeps the immovable bed while Odysseus wanders, and punctures the *witch-loop* through which persecution manufactures the witch it claims to fear.

The argument unfolds across eight chapters that read the game alongside the originators of its governing ideas, from Plato, Augustine, Boethius, Kant, Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Bergson, Heidegger, Benjamin, Arendt, Levinas, Derrida, Deleuze, Stiegler and Badiou to Dōgen, Zeami, Kuki Shūzō, Nishida Kitarō, Watsuji Tetsurō, Nishitani Keiji, Doi Takeo, Kawai Hayao, Ōtsuka Eiji and Azuma Hiroki, and in sustained comparison with speculative and philosophical fiction from Homer, Dante, Goethe and Borges to Le Guin, Ende, Ishiguro, Murakami, Pullman, Chris Marker, Alain Resnais, *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, *Revolutionary Girl Utena* and *Puella Magi Madoka Magica*. A final chapter turns the framework upon the medium itself, reading the save point as a rendezvous, the player as an Ellone-figure who projects consciousness into a fictive past, and the three canonical fan hypotheses (that Squall dies at the end of the first disc, that Rinoa becomes Ultimecia, that Laguna is Squall's father) as vernacular attempts to close, respectively, the chronological, genealogical and mnemonic dispossessions that the game deliberately holds open. The thesis concludes that *Final Fantasy VIII* is best understood not as a love story ornamenting a time-travel plot, but as an argument that love, construed as the topological fidelity of the Two, is the one form of temporality that cannot be compressed.

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Prefatory Note

on Corpus, Citation, Translation, and Transliteration

The primary text is *Final Fantasy VIII* as first released for the Sony PlayStation in Japan on 11 February 1999 and in English-language markets later that year, together with its Windows port (2000) and the Remastered edition (2019) where the latter's affordances bear on the argument (Chapter Eight). The game is treated as a single text distributed across three registers: the *diegetic* (script, cinematics, music, mise-en-scène), the *procedural* (the Junction system, Draw, refinement, level scaling, the SeeD salary, the card game Triple Triad, the architecture of saving), and the *paratextual* (official guides and published developer commentary, invoked only where their content is general and well established). Structural references follow the four-disc partition of the original release.

Dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted. This is partly a matter of respect for the localized text and partly a matter of method: the English localization diverges from the Japanese script in register and idiom, so that analysis anchored in verbatim English risks mistaking a translator's choices for the authors'. Where a term's Japanese form matters it is supplied; the final antagonist, localized as Ultimecia, is アルティミシア (Arutimishia) in the original. Song lyrics, including those of the choral "Liberi Fatali" and the theme "Eyes on Me," are discussed but never reproduced.

Citations follow author–date conventions; where a translation is cited, the year of original publication appears in square brackets. Classical and scriptural texts are cited by standard divisions (Stephanus and Bekker pagination, book and line, chapter and verse), Kant by the A/B pagination of the first and second editions. Japanese authors and scholars appear in Japanese order, family name first (Kuki Shūzō, Watsuji Tetsurō, Azuma Hiroki), save that the game's developers appear in the Western order of their international credits. Long vowels are marked with macrons.

The fan hypotheses examined in Chapter Eight are treated as phenomena of reception, not as canon. The thesis distinguishes throughout between *genealogy* (sources that plausibly shaped the work or its milieu), *homology* (works that share a problem without relations of influence), and *instrumentality* (philosophical tools brought to the text by the critic). No claim is made that the developers read Kierkegaard or Kuki; the claim is that the game thinks what they thought, by other means.

The following coined terms recur and are developed where they first appear.

TERM	WORKING DEFINITION	DEVELOPED IN
General economy of convertibility	The systemic logic in which every value (magic, cards, experience, persons, time) is exchangeable for every other	Chapters One and Five
Junctional subject	A subject constituted at the coupling point of borrowed powers, paying for capacity with recollection	Chapter One
Epimethean institution	An institution founded on an afterthought delivered from its own future, and producing forgetful subjects	Chapters One and Five
Witch-loop	The circuit in which an institution founded to hunt the witch manufactures the witch it hunts	Chapter Four
Compressive sovereignty	The claim of a single will to decide upon the exception of time itself	Chapter Five
Inconvertible remainder	That which cannot be drawn, stocked, refined, junctioned or exchanged: the promise	Chapters Five and Seven
Deposited ipseity	Selfhood held in trust by another and recovered by being found	Chapter Seven
Promissory chronotope	A place in which a promise binds future to past, softening temporal boundaries without collapsing them	Chapter Seven
Aprosopic rendezvous	A meeting accomplished in the absence of the remembered face, which thereby admits the face as event rather than image	Chapter Seven
Rendezvous ontology	The account of the self as constituted by appointments kept, rather than by memory, narrative, resolve or fusion	Chapter Seven

INTRODUCTION

The Lion, the Witch, and the Flower Field

Quid est ergo tempus? Si nemo ex me quaerat, scio; si quaerenti explicare velim, nescio.

What then is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know.

AUGUSTINE, CONFESSIONES XI.14.17

Final Fantasy VIII is a philosophical text whose alleged incoherences are its argument. The features most often cited against it (a progression system that can be "broken" within hours, enemies that grow stronger in lockstep with the player, a love story pursued with an earnestness that embarrassed many contemporary reviewers, and a final act in which chronology itself disintegrates) are read here not as failures of design but as the procedural and narrative articulation of a single problem: what remains of a self when its memory, its origin and its time have each been converted into something else. The title of this introduction borrows its first two terms from C. S. Lewis, whose Narnia opens under a witch who has frozen time into an endless winter and a lion whose death and return set it moving again (Lewis 1950). *Final Fantasy VIII* rearranges these figures with deliberate perversity. Its lion, Squall Leonhart, whose surname, ring and private emblem all invoke the animal, must be killed in his own imagination; its witch is at once the beloved and the destroyer of time; and the force that restarts history is neither sacrifice nor resurrection but a third term that Lewis's allegory lacks, a field of flowers where someone has promised to wait.

I.1 An Unfinished Reception

Released in Japan on 11 February 1999, between the global breakthrough of *Final Fantasy VII* (1997) and the self-consciously retrospective *Final Fantasy IX* (2000), the eighth entry was a commercial phenomenon and a critical irritant. Its reception has been structured by comparison. Set beside the ecological and corporate allegory of its predecessor, the game appeared privatized, adolescent, absorbed in the interiority of a sullen protagonist; set beside the series' conventions of growth, its Junction system appeared perverse. Academic attention has followed the same gradient. Where *Final Fantasy VII* has attracted sustained commentary, the eighth entry has received chapter-length treatment at most, notably within the philosophy-and-popular-culture volume edited by Blahuta and Beaulieu (2009), and incidental mention in broader studies of Japanese games in global circulation (Consalvo 2016; Hutchinson 2019). The formative debates of game studies, between a ludological emphasis on rule and a narratological emphasis on story (Aarseth 1997; Murray 1997; Jenkins 2004; Juul 2005), were conducted largely through Western exemplars, and the Japanese role-playing game was typically received either as an interactive novel or as an ethnographic artifact of "Japaneseness."

Against both reductions, this thesis treats *Final Fantasy VIII* as a work of thought. Its unusual density of what Wolfgang Iser called *Leerstellen*, the blanks a text leaves for its reader to fill (Iser 1978 [1976]), is attested by the fertility of its fan hermeneutics. No other entry in the series has generated hypotheses as persistent or as structurally ambitious as the claims that its hero dies at the end of the first disc, that its heroine becomes its villain, and that its comic secondary protagonist is the hero's unacknowledged father. Chapter Eight argues that these hypotheses are not idle speculation but vernacular philosophy, each an attempt to close one of the three dispossessions that the game deliberately holds open. A text that so reliably provokes its readers into metaphysics deserves to be read metaphysically.

1.2 Triangulated Authorship: Kitase, Nojima, Ito

The question of authorship in large-scale game production is acute. Foucault's account of the author as a *function*, a principle of classification and limitation rather than an originating consciousness (Foucault 1977 [1969]), and Barthes's earlier proclamation of the author's death (Barthes 1977 [1967]), might seem to dissolve the question entirely for a work produced by a team numbering well over a hundred. Yet *Final Fantasy VIII* exhibits a legible convergence of three authorial lineages, and the thesis proposes to treat its authorship as itself a *junction*: a coupling of heterogeneous capacities, none of which subsumes the others.

The first lineage is Yoshinori Kitase's. Before directing *Final Fantasy VII* and *VIII*, Kitase codirected *Final Fantasy VI* (1994) with Hiroyuki Ito and *Chrono Trigger* (1995) with Takashi Tokita and Akihiko Matsui. The latter remains the genre's canonical meditation on time travel, built upon a voluntarist model in which history can be altered and catastrophic futures averted. *Final Fantasy VIII* abandons that model for its opposite, a self-consistent loop in which the past cannot be changed and the future has, in a sense, already occurred; the passage from the earlier game's mutable timelines to the later game's closed circuit is among the most significant and least remarked transformations in the genre's philosophy of time (Chapter Five). Kitase also presided over the series' cinematic turn: the integration of full-motion video with play and, in this entry, the adoption of realistically proportioned character models. His widely reported framing of love as the project's thematic center is taken here not as an advertising formula but as a philosophical wager.

The second lineage is Kazushige Nojima's. Before joining Square in the mid-1990s, Nojima wrote scenarios for Data East's *Heracles no Eikō* series, whose third installment (1992) follows an immortal protagonist without memory. His subsequent work, from the counterfeit recollections of *Final Fantasy VII*'s Cloud Strife through the amnesiac orphans of *Final Fantasy VIII* to the dream-born protagonist of *Final Fantasy X* (2001), returns with the regularity of an obsession to the dependence of identity upon recollection and to the vulnerability of recollection to others. The thesis calls this Nojima's *mnemonic problematic*.

The third lineage is Hiroyuki Ito's. Ito's Active Time Battle system, introduced in *Final Fantasy IV* (1991), first subordinated combat to a running clock; his later direction of *Final Fantasy IX* and co-direction of *Final Fantasy XII* (2006), with its programmable Gambits, extended a single tendency, the migration of player agency from moment-to-moment input toward architectonic configuration. The Junction system, which detaches power from level and relocates it in the arrangement of borrowed capacities within a character's parameter sheet, is the most radical moment in that trajectory. The thesis calls this Ito's *architectonic problematic*.

To these must be added Tetsuya Nomura's character design, Yusuke Naora's art direction and Nobuo Uematsu's score, including the Latin choral overture "Liberi Fatali" ("Fated Children") and the theme "Eyes on Me," performed by Faye Wong. But the philosophical content of the work emerges with particular clarity at the intersection of the three lineages first named: a cinematic temporality (Kitase) inhabited by subjects whose memory is precarious (Nojima) within a

system that converts every capacity into a configurable parameter (Ito). *Final Fantasy VIII* is what happens when these three problematics are junctioned.

1.3 Method: Ludo-Hermeneutic Close Reading and Comparative Genealogy

The method adopted here is a *ludo-hermeneutic close reading*: the systematic interpretation of rules, interfaces, level design, script, cinematics and music as co-constitutive registers of a single text. It draws on Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric, according to which games argue through the processes they enact (Bogost 2007); on Espen Aarseth's concept of the ergodic, in which nontrivial effort is required to traverse a text (Aarseth 1997); on Alexander Galloway's analysis of gamic action as an algorithmic mode of culture (Galloway 2006); and on Lev Manovich's account of the database as a symbolic form in structural tension with narrative (Manovich 2001). Its premise is that a rule can bear meaning as precisely as a sentence: that casting a spell weakens the caster, or that monsters yield no money while the hero draws a salary, is as interpretable as any line of dialogue.

The comparative dimension proceeds along the three axes distinguished in the prefatory note. *Genealogy* attends to sources that plausibly shaped the work or its milieu: *Chrono Trigger*, *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, the popular psychoanalysis of *amae* and of the "moratorium" generation, the millenarian atmosphere of late-1990s Japan. *Homology* attends to works that share the game's problems without relations of influence, from Homer's *Odyssey* to Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials*. *Instrumentality* brings philosophical concepts to bear without claiming that the developers possessed them. Confusing these axes is the characteristic vice of cultural criticism; separating them is a condition of intellectual honesty.

A further commitment concerns the status of Japanese thought. Sakai Naoki has diagnosed a "schema of co-figuration" in which "Japan" and "the West" are constituted as mutually defining unities, the former habitually positioned as object and the latter as theory (Sakai 1997). This thesis refuses the asymmetry. Dōgen, Zeami, Kuki Shūzō, Nishida Kitarō, Watsuji Tetsurō and Nishitani Keiji are treated not as ethnographic context but as philosophers whose concepts are as available for critical use as Heidegger's or Derrida's.

Refusing the asymmetry also means applying the same political scrutiny to every tradition the thesis draws on, and stating the record plainly rather than gesturing at it. Between November 1941 and November 1942, Nishitani Keiji, Kōyama Iwao, Kōsaka Masaaki and Suzuki Shigetaka held three roundtables, published in the journal *Chūōkōron* and collected in 1943 as *The World-Historical Standpoint and Japan*, which presented Japan's war in Asia and the Pacific as a world-historical mission to overcome Western modernity and supplied philosophical terms for the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere; Nishitani and Suzuki also took part in the July 1942 symposium on "Overcoming Modernity" (Calichman 2008). Nishida's 1943 essay "The Principle of the New World Order," prepared at the request of figures connected to the army and the National Policy Research Association, framed the Co-Prosperity Sphere in the language of his philosophy;

whether it endorsed the regime's aims or sought to redirect them remains debated (Heisig and Maraldo 1994). Watsuji's ethics placed the state at the summit of the forms of betweenness, and his wartime writing on reverence for the emperor carried that hierarchy into imperial ideology (Watsuji 1943). The war these writings dignified was a war of aggression waged by the Japanese state in China from 1937 and across Southeast Asia and the Pacific from 1941, in the course of which the Imperial Japanese Army massacred civilians and prisoners at Nanjing in 1937–38 and the military operated a system of sexual slavery. The European sources require the same accounting. Heidegger joined the National Socialist Party in 1933 and served as rector of the University of Freiburg in 1933–34, and his posthumously published notebooks contain antisemitic passages (Heidegger 2014). Carl Schmitt joined the party the same year and in 1934 publicly justified the extrajudicial killings of the Night of the Long Knives (Schmitt 1934). Paul de Man wrote for the collaborationist Belgian newspaper *Le Soir* in 1940–42, including an antisemitic article in 1941 (de Man 1988). Mircea Eliade published articles in the 1930s supporting Romania's fascist Legionary Movement. Jung, presiding over an international society for psychotherapy in the 1930s, wrote in 1934 of differences between "Aryan" and "Jewish" psychology (Jung 1964 [1934]).

These facts do not invalidate the concepts drawn from these thinkers, but they bear on the argument rather than standing beside it as disclaimers. The Kyoto School's wartime discourse is a political form of what Chapter Five calls compressive sovereignty: the absorption of many peoples and histories into a single world-historical order under one center, the spatial counterpart of Ultimecia's temporal project. Heidegger's resolute being-toward-death and Schmitt's decision upon the exception are precisely the paradigms the game's ethic of the rendezvous is read here as refusing. Every concept in this thesis is deployed with attention to the totalizing uses to which it has been put.

I.4 The Argument: Three Dispossessions and an Inconvertible Remainder

The thesis advances one central claim and four subordinate claims. The central claim is that *Final Fantasy VIII* develops, through the integrated operation of its systems and its story, a *rendezvous ontology*: an account of the self as constituted not by what it remembers, narrates, decides or fuses with, but by the appointments it keeps with others, at places that hold time without abolishing it.

The first subordinate claim is that the game stages three dispossessions. *Mnemonic dispossession* is the conversion of memory into power through the Guardian Forces. *Genealogical dispossession* is the absence of origin in a world where institutions are founded from their own futures and power descends through a succession with no first term. *Chronological dispossession* is the threat that all time will be compressed into a single instant possessed by a single will.

The second is that these dispossessions express one systemic logic, the *general economy of convertibility*, visible in the Junction system's exchange of magic for attributes, in the card game's conversion of collected beings into items, in the salary that converts conduct into currency, and in Time Compression's conversion of duration into instant.

The third is that the game identifies a single remainder this economy cannot convert: the promise made at a place, which is neither a quantity, nor a memory, nor a capacity, but a topology of fidelity.

The fourth is that this remainder is formally asymmetric and politically consequential. A rendezvous requires one party who abides and one who seeks. In the game's resolution the knight abides and the sorceress seeks, inverting the Homeric gender topology of fidelity and suspending the persecutory circuit in which the hunted sorceress becomes the monster that justifies her hunt.

These claims position rendezvous ontology against four rival paradigms of identity. Against the *mnemonic* paradigm descending from Locke, it holds that a self can survive the loss of continuous recollection. Against the *narrative* paradigm of Ricoeur and MacIntyre, insofar as narration presupposes memory, it holds that selfhood can be maintained by a promise without a story. Against the *decisionist* paradigm that runs from Heidegger's resolute being-toward-death through Schmitt's sovereign to the "survival" narratives that Uno Tsunehiro identified as successors to the withdrawal fantasies of the 1990s (Uno 2008), it holds that the decisive act is not a decision upon an exception but fidelity to an appointment. Against the *fusional* paradigm that runs from Aristophanes' speech in the *Symposium* to the Human Instrumentality Project of *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, it holds that love preserves the interval between the Two.

One further claim is ventured with deliberate boldness. The genre that Japanese criticism of the early 2000s named *sekai-kei* ("world-type"), in which the intimate relation of a boy and a girl is coupled directly to the fate of the world without the mediation of society, finds in *Final Fantasy VIII* an unacknowledged precursor that also anticipates the genre's critique. The game evacuates the social as decisively as any later *sekai-kei* text, but it inserts between the lovers and the world a third term that the genre characteristically lacks: the place.

1.5 Plan of the Thesis

Chapter One, "The Pharmacy of the Garden," reconstructs the Junction system as a philosophy of the *pharmakon*, reading the Guardian Forces through Plato's *Phaedrus*, Derrida and Stiegler; Draw and the stocking of magic through Heidegger's standing-reserve and Bataille's general economy; para-magic through Baudrillard and Benjamin; level scaling through Benjamin's poverty of experience; the SeeD salary through Foucault's entrepreneur of the self; and the junction menu through Manovich, Ōtsuka and Azuma. It concludes by defining the junctional subject.

Chapter Two, "Liberi Fatali," turns to the orphans, reading Squall's parenthetical interiority through Bakhtin and Dostoevsky, his shut-upness through Kierkegaard's inclosing reserve, his refusal of dependence through Doi, Winnicott and Klein, the Garden through Erikson's and Okonogi's moratorium, his development through Nietzsche's three metamorphoses, his rivalry with Seifer through Lacan, Hegel and Girard, and his final orientation through Watsuji's ethics of betweenness.

Chapter Three, "The Secret Verabredung," reads the Laguna sequences as a structural analogue of Zeami's dream Noh, Ellone's lesson of irreversibility through Novikov, Lewis, Chiang

and Arendt, and the transmission between generations through Benjamin's second thesis on history, Abraham and Torok's phantom, Levinas's fecundity, Proust's little phrase and Bakhtin's idyll.

Chapter Four, "The Succession of Witches," examines the mythology of sorcery, the Lunatic Pandora, the containment of sorceresses, the angel–witch dialectic, the onomastics of Edea and Ultimecia, and the figure of the knight, and identifies the witch-loop and its puncture.

Chapter Five, "Tota Simul," reconstructs Time Compression through Boethius, Aquinas and Augustine; Hesiod and Goya; Goethe, Kant and Hegel; Derrida's critique of presence; Gödel, Novikov and Lewis on closed time; Harvey, Jameson, Virilio and Berardi on capitalist temporality; Paul and Agamben on messianic contraction; and Dōgen, Nishida and Nishitani on non-compressive totality.

Chapter Six, "Griever," reads the final dungeon as the systematic disassembly of the junctional subject and the final adversary as the hero's imagination turned against him.

Chapter Seven, "The Flower Field," formalizes rendezvous ontology through Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Arendt, Ricoeur, Levinas, Badiou, Homer, Bakhtin, Nishida, Bloch, Zeami and Kuki, concluding with twelve propositions and a comparative coda.

Chapter Eight, "The Save Point," turns the framework upon the medium, reading the save point, the player, counter-play, fan theory and the remaster. The Conclusion assesses the thesis's contributions and limits.

CHAPTER ONE

The Pharmacy of the Garden

Guardian Forces, Para-Magic, and Mnemonic Dispossession

οὔκουν μνήμης ἀλλὰ ὑπομνήσεως φάρμακον ηὗρες.

You have found a remedy not for memory, but for reminding.

PLATO, PHAEDRUS 275A

THE Junction system is a philosophy of the *pharmakon* rendered as a rule-set: it makes power and memory exchangeable, and it makes that exchange the condition of every capacity the player possesses. This chapter reconstructs the system's architecture, identifies the price the narrative assigns to it, and argues that its notorious exploitability is the procedural signature of a world in which every value is convertible into every other.

1.1 The Architecture of Junction

The Junction system replaces the genre's customary reservoir of magic points with three interlocking operations. First, the player *junctions* Guardian Forces (GFs), summoned entities possessing their own hit points, compatibility values and repertoires of learnable abilities, to individual characters; without a junctioned GF, a character can do little but attack. Second, magic is not learned but *drawn*: extracted in discrete units from enemies in combat or from draw points distributed through the world, or else manufactured by *refining* items and cards through abilities the GFs teach. Each character may stock up to one hundred units of a given spell across a limited number of slots. Third, stocked magic is *junctioned* to a character's attributes (strength, vitality, magic, spirit, speed, evasion, accuracy, and elemental and status attack and defense), where its bonus scales with both the spell's potency and the quantity held. Ten units of a spell junctioned to strength confer a modest increase; one hundred units of its most powerful form transform the character.

Three corollaries govern the rest of the game. The first is that casting a spell consumes a unit of stock and thereby diminishes whatever attribute that stock has been junctioned to: to use magic is to weaken oneself. The second is that enemies scale with the party's level, so that experience accumulated through combat confers little relative advantage; power is a function of configuration, not of time spent. The third is that monsters yield no money. Gil arrives instead as a salary, paid at intervals measured in the player's steps and determined by a SeeD rank that rises and falls with conduct in battle, written examinations and behavior in the field. Around these corollaries cluster subsidiary mechanisms. Limit Breaks become available when a character's hit points fall into a critical band, or under the status Aura. The Boost mechanic lets the player intensify a GF's attack by rapid input during its summoning. And the card game Triple Triad, presented as a diversion, becomes through the GF ability Card Mod a source of items that can be refined into the most potent magic in the game.

The system was received as exploitable, and it is. A player who understands refinement can junction spells of late-game potency within the first hours, rendering subsequent encounters trivial; a player who avoids combat can complete the game at very low levels. The argument of this chapter is that the exploitability is not incidental. A system in which every value is convertible into every other must, by its nature, permit arbitrage. The Junction system is the procedural form of a world in which nothing possesses an intrinsic measure, in which power, memory, money and time are mutually exchangeable. This is what the thesis calls the *general economy of convertibility*, in deliberate inversion of Georges Bataille's "general economy" of unproductive expenditure (Bataille 1988 [1949]). Where Bataille's general economy is defined by the excess that cannot be accumulat-

ed, the game's is defined by the accumulation of everything, including what ought to be inexhaustible.

1.2 Theuth's Gift: The Guardian Force as Pharmakon

The narrative supplies the system's price midway through the second disc. At the ruins of Trabia Garden, Irvine Kinneas reveals to his companions that they were raised together in an orphanage by the sea, under the care of a woman they called Matron, and that this woman is the sorceress Edea whom they have been fighting. That the others have forgotten is attributed to the Guardian Forces, understood to occupy the region of the mind in which memory resides; Irvine, whose exposure to GFs has been more limited, remembers. Having learned this, the company elects to continue using the GFs, since they cannot fight without them. The scene is the philosophical center of the game's first half. It converts an interface convention into a Faustian contract and then has its signatories sign a second time, knowingly.

The structure is Platonic. In the *Phaedrus*, Socrates recounts how the Egyptian god Theuth presented his inventions, writing among them, to King Thamus, praising writing as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom. Thamus replies that it will implant forgetfulness (*lēthē*) in the souls of those who learn it, since they will cease to exercise memory (*mnēmē*) and rely instead on external marks; it is a remedy not for memory but for reminding (*hypomnēsis*), offering the semblance of wisdom rather than its substance (*Phaedrus* 274c–275b). Derrida's reading turns on the undecidability of *pharmakon*, which signifies both remedy and poison and which Plato's text cannot stabilize in either sense (Derrida 1981 [1968]). The Guardian Force is a pharmakon in exactly this undecidable sense: it enables the orphans to survive and erases the knowledge of who they are; it strengthens the capacity to act while dissolving the memory that would give action its reasons.

Derrida's reading also discloses a lexical chain that the game distributes across its systems with uncanny exactness. *Pharmakon* (drug, remedy, poison) belongs to a family that includes *pharmakeus* (sorcerer, poisoner), *pharmakis* (sorceress, witch) and *pharmakos* (the scapegoat expelled from the city to purify it). Derrida notes that Socrates himself is figured as a *pharmakeus* in the dialogues, and that the ritual of the *pharmakos* haunts Plato's text without being named in it. *Final Fantasy VIII* realizes the entire chain. Its prosthetic power is the pharmakon (the GF); its authentic and feared power belongs to the pharmakis (the sorceress); and its political drama is that of the pharmakos (the sorceress hunted, sealed and expelled, Chapter Four). The game's two loci of magic are etymological kin, and the antagonism between them is an antagonism within a single word.

Speculative fiction has repeatedly imagined this bargain, and three versions sharpen its terms. In Michael Ende's *The Neverending Story* (1979), every wish that Bastian makes with the amulet AURYN is paid for with a memory of his life in the human world; as his power grows he forgets, piece by piece, his life, his family and finally his own name, and he is warned of the City of the Old Emperors, where those who spent all their memories on wishes live on without the ability to wish at all, since wishing requires a past to wish from. He is saved only through his friend Atreyu's fidelity, and his last wish is to be able to love (Ende 1983 [1979]). In Black Isle Studios' *Planescape: Torment* (1999), released in the same year as *Final Fantasy VIII*, an immortal protagonist loses his

memory with every death and pays for each revival with the life of someone else. And in Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Buried Giant* (2015), discussed in 7.11, collective forgetting is a political anesthetic, induced deliberately to preserve a peace founded on a massacre. Ende's version is the closest to the game's structure and anticipates its solution: the self that has spent its memory on power is recovered not by remembering but by another who keeps faith with it.

1.3 Epimethean Prosthesis: Stiegler, Tertiary Retention, and the Proletarianization of Memory

Bernard Stiegler's philosophy of technics radicalizes the Platonic problem by making it constitutive of the human. In the myth Plato assigns to Protagoras, Epimetheus, entrusted with distributing qualities to mortal creatures, exhausts them on the animals and forgets humankind, whereupon Prometheus steals fire and the technical arts to compensate (*Protagoras* 320c–322a). Stiegler reads this as a "default of origin": the human is the being without qualities whose essence is supplied by prosthesis and whose memory is accordingly exteriorized in technical supports, a process he names *epiphylogenesis* (Stiegler 1998 [1994]). Extending Husserl's distinction between primary retention (the just-past held in the living present) and secondary retention (recollection), Stiegler names the memory inscribed in technical objects *tertiary retention* and argues that all memory is from the outset conditioned by it. Tertiary retentions are pharmacological: they can sustain individuation or, when industrialized and controlled by others, produce a "proletarianization" in which subjects lose their know-how and their knowledge of how to live (Stiegler 2013 [2010]).

The Guardian Force is a tertiary retention turned inside out. It does not store memory outside the subject; it stores capacity inside the subject at the expense of memory. It is an anti-*hypomnēma*, a prosthesis of power paid for in recollection. The SeeD cadet is accordingly the proletarianized subject par excellence: he has acquired the combat competence the institution requires and lost the knowledge of where he came from and to whom he belongs. That the Guardian Forces are issued and administered by the Garden, which schools its students in their use, makes the analogy institutional as well as psychological. And the Garden itself, as Chapter Five demonstrates, is founded upon an afterthought delivered from its own future, a literal *epi-mētheia*. The thesis therefore calls it an *Epimethean institution*: founded under forgetting's mythical patron, and manufacturing forgetful subjects.

Gilbert Simondon's concept of transindividuation, on which Stiegler draws, adds a further dimension: psychic and collective individuation co-occur, and no subject individuates alone (Simondon 2020 [1958]). The orphans' amnesia severs not only each individual's past but the transindividual field in which they were individuated together, and the recovery at Trabia is accordingly collective; each recollection triggers another, as though memory were a commons that could be reconstituted only in assembly. Maurice Halbwachs's argument that individual memory depends upon social frameworks, so that we remember as members of groups (Halbwachs 1992 [1925]), is staged here almost diagrammatically: the orphans can remember the orphanage only together.

1.4 The Failure of Reproduction: Kant, Locke, and the Orphans' Amnesia

The epistemological stakes can be specified with Kantian precision. In the first-edition Transcendental Deduction, Kant distinguishes three syntheses required for cognition: the apprehension of the manifold in intuition, its reproduction in imagination, and its recognition in a concept. Without reproduction, if one always lost the preceding representations from thought on proceeding to the next, no whole representation could ever arise, not even the purest representations of space and time (A100–A102). The GF amnesia is a localized failure of the synthesis of reproduction at the scale of biography. The transcendental unity of apperception survives formally, since Squall still says "I" and the "I think" can still accompany his representations, but the reproducible manifold of a life has been evacuated. What remains is apperception without autobiography: a formal self with nothing to synthesize.

The game thereby stages the classical crisis of personal identity. For Locke, personal identity extends exactly as far as consciousness can be extended backward to past actions or thoughts (*Essay* II.xxvii.9). By this criterion the SeeD who fights the sorceress is not the same person as the orphan who called her Matron, a conclusion that would absolve him of the orphan's attachments and deprive him of the orphan's claims. Thomas Reid's objection of the brave officer, who as a young officer remembers his boyhood flogging and as an old general remembers only his youthful exploit, showed that the Lockean criterion violates the transitivity of identity (Reid 1785, Essay III, ch. 6). Derek Parfit's response was to abandon identity as what matters, replacing it with psychological connectedness and continuity ("Relation R"), which can hold in degrees and by any cause (Parfit 1984). The orphans occupy precisely the Parfitian situation: weak connectedness to their childhood selves, restored by a social cause, Irvine's testimony, and survival by degrees rather than all-or-nothing identity. Chapter Seven argues that the game finally refuses both the Lockean and the Parfitian solutions in favor of a third, in which what matters is neither identity nor connectedness but fidelity held by another.

1.5 Standing-Reserve: Draw, Stock, and the Hoarder's Paradox

The Draw command transforms the relation between subject and world. In Heidegger's late account, modern technology differs from earlier *technē* in its mode of revealing: it "challenges forth" (*herausfordern*) nature, setting upon it to deliver energy that can be extracted and stored, so that everything is revealed as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, held on call for further ordering; the essence of technology is the *Gestell*, the enframing that gathers this setting-upon (Heidegger 1977 [1954]). Heidegger's emblem is the hydroelectric plant that converts Hölderlin's Rhine into a water-power supplier. The game's draw points, luminous sites where magic wells from the earth to be extracted in quantified units, are Rhine dams in miniature; its enemies are walking reservoirs of extractable power; its menus display the world's magic as inventory, each spell a line item with a count. The danger Heidegger identifies, that the human being too becomes standing-reserve, is realized in SeeD, whose students are trained, ranked and contracted out as a reserve of human force available to any client.

The rule that casting consumes stock and weakens junctioned attributes produces what may be called the *hoarder's paradox*. Magic is most valuable unspent; its utility lies in potentiality. Experienced players cast sparingly, preferring to keep one hundred units of a powerful spell junctioned to an attribute than to release a single unit against an enemy. Marx's portrait of the hoarder, who sacrifices the lusts of the flesh to the fetish of gold and must withhold his treasure from circulation to preserve it (Marx 1976 [1867], ch. 3), describes with surprising fidelity the disposition the system cultivates. Bataille's distinction between restricted economies, organized around accumulation and productive use, and the general economy, which must sooner or later expend its excess gloriously and without return (Bataille 1988 [1949]), maps onto the game's two kinds of magic. Para-magic is restricted: stocked, counted, junctioned, hoarded. The sorceress's magic is general: it is neither drawn nor stocked but simply *is*, unlimited and expended at will, and for precisely this reason it is feared, contained and hunted. The political drama of the game's second half is a conflict between a restricted economy of power and a general one.

1.6 Para-Magic and the Precession of Simulacra

The game's lore insists that the magic its soldiers use is not magic in the full sense. The localization calls it "para-magic," an imitative capacity developed by the Estharian scientist Dr. Odine through the study of sorceresses. Para-magic is thus a copy whose original is the sorceress's power, a relation that invites Baudrillard's genealogy of simulacra: the counterfeit, which acknowledges its original; production, the serial manufacture of equivalent copies; and simulation, in which the copy precedes and determines the original (Baudrillard 1993 [1976]; 1994 [1981]). Para-magic is a second-order simulacrum aspiring to the third order. Because it is the only magic most of the world's subjects encounter, it defines what "magic" means; the sorceress's power becomes by contrast an anomaly, a deviation from a norm that was itself derived from her.

Walter Benjamin's essay on technical reproducibility supplies a complementary vocabulary. Reproduction detaches the object from the domain of tradition and withers its *aura*, which Ben-

jamin defines as the unique apparition of a distance, however near it may be (Benjamin 1968 [1935–36]). Para-magic is magic in the age of its technical reproducibility: serial, portable, quantified, auratic only at its source. The sorceress is the auratic original, and the game's treatment of her, at once sublime and dangerous, paraded as Galbadia's ambassador in Deling City and sealed in Esthar's Sorceress Memorial, reproduces the ambivalence with which aura survives in the age of reproduction, returning as cult and as threat. Dr. Odine's laboratory, where sorcery is studied, imitated and contained, is the institutional site at which aura is captured for reproduction.

1.7 Level Scaling and the Poverty of Experience

Level scaling dismantles the genre's foundational promise: that time spent fighting accumulates as power, so that the hero grows through trial into mastery. Because enemies scale with the party, accumulated experience yields almost no relative gain; what alters the balance of power is the configuration of junctions, which can be optimized at any point independently of time spent. The system abolishes, at the level of rule, the *Bildung* that the story of a seventeen-year-old cadet would otherwise seem to promise.

Benjamin anticipated this condition in two interwar essays. In "Experience and Poverty" (1933) he observes that the generation that went to school in horse-drawn streetcars returned from the Great War poorer in communicable experience; in "The Storyteller" (1936) he traces the decline of storytelling to the displacement of transmissible experience by information (Benjamin 1999 [1933]; 1968 [1936]). His distinction between *Erfahrung*, accumulated and transmissible experience, and *Erlebnis*, the isolated lived moment, is mirrored in the difference between leveling and junctioning: the former accumulates, the latter configures. The Junction system is an *Erlebnis* economy, in which a character's value is the value of her current configuration rather than the sediment of her history. Franco Moretti's account of the Bildungsroman as the symbolic form of modernity, in which youth figures modernity's restlessness and the plot negotiates between self-determination and socialization (Moretti 1987), clarifies what is refused. At the level of its rules, *Final Fantasy VIII* is an anti-Bildungsroman: growth through accumulation is futile. Its story insists that growth is possible, but only through relation. The divergence is not "ludonarrative dissonance" in Clint Hocking's sense (Hocking 2007) but a deliberate counterpoint. The system says that time spent alone yields nothing; the story says what does.

1.8 The Salaried Hero: SeeD Rank and the Entrepreneur of the Self

The absence of monetary drops from defeated monsters is among the most quietly radical decisions in the design. The archaic hero lives by plunder; this hero lives by wage. His income is a salary disbursed according to a rank that measures performance, rising with victories and passed examinations and falling with flight from battle and misconduct. The hero is an employee whose remuneration is indexed to a continuously updated evaluation of his conduct.

Foucault's lectures on neoliberalism describe the transformation this presupposes. Neoliberal *homo economicus* is no longer a partner in exchange but an "entrepreneur of himself," his own cap-

ital, his own producer, the source of his own earnings (Foucault 2008 [1979]). Michel Feher extended the analysis to human capital as a regime of perpetual self-appreciation, the subject as a portfolio whose value must be maintained against continuous assessment (Feher 2009). SeeD rank is a credit rating of the self. Its fluctuations convert every encounter into a performance review, and its written tests, accessible from the tutorial menu, extend evaluation into the player's own knowledge of the system.

The historical resonance is precise. The game was developed in the aftermath of the collapse of Japan's asset bubble, as the postwar settlement of lifetime employment eroded and new graduates entered what the Japanese press called the "employment ice age." The *furītā*, the young worker in contingent employment, had entered public discourse. SeeD is the fantasy image of this generation: skilled, credentialed, contracted, mobile and without security, sold by the mission to whichever client can pay, including, at the game's opening, a ragtag resistance movement in occupied Timber. The Garden's internal politics, in which the headmaster Cid's hidden purpose contends with the profit motive of Norg, the Shumi financier whose capital built the institution, mark it as a corporate academy.

Foucault's earlier account of discipline completes the picture. The examination, combining hierarchical observation with normalizing judgment, renders individuals visible as cases (Foucault 1977 [1975]); Balamb Garden's field examination at Dollet, its rankings and its student Disciplinary Committee under Seifer Almasy instantiate the apparatus almost too literally. The Garden's architecture, a ring of facilities arrayed around a central hall and an elevator rising to the headmaster's office, is a diffuse panopticism in which the center is less a watchtower than a hub of administration.

The Garden's institutional form also changes in the course of the game, and the change has a precise theoretical name. Midway through the second disc, threatened by missiles, Balamb Garden reveals itself to be a mobile structure and lifts off, drifting across the sea; it runs aground at Fishermen's Horizon, a town of engineers built on an abandoned transcontinental bridge whose mayor rejects violence, and it later engages Galbadia Garden in open battle. In *A Thousand Plateaus*, Deleuze and Guattari distinguish the state apparatus, sedentary and striating, from the war machine, which is exterior to the state, nomadic and native to smooth space, of which the sea is their paradigm; states capture war machines as armies, and mercenaries are war machines for hire (Deleuze and Guattari 1987 [1980]). The Garden's lift-off transforms a disciplinary institution into a nomadic war machine, and Fishermen's Horizon, a community that settles on infrastructure the states abandoned and refuses the war machine's logic, is its counterpoint. The Garden's arrival brings war to a town that wanted none, and the scene stages, without resolving, the question of whether an institution built to sell force can belong anywhere.

1.9 Database Animals: The Junction Menu as Symbolic Form

Lev Manovich argued that the database is the symbolic form of the computer age, in the sense Panofsky gave to linear perspective, and that database and narrative are natural enemies: a database presents the world as an unordered collection of items, while narrative constructs a trajectory of cause and effect. In new media, Manovich observed, the paradigmatic dimension, the set of elements from which choices are made, acquires material existence, while the syntagmatic dimension, the realized sequence, is dematerialized (Manovich 2001). The junction menu is a materialized paradigm. A character appears there as an array of slots, for GFs, abilities, commands and attributes, into which drawn elements are inserted; party members are interchangeable configurations, and when one leaves the party her junctions can be transferred wholesale to another. Character becomes parameter sheet.

Japanese criticism of the period offers a more specific genealogy. Ōtsuka Eiji's theory of "narrative consumption" (1989) observed that children collecting the stickers packaged with Bikkuriman chocolates were consuming, through each sticker, a fragment of a grand narrative or "worldview" (*sekaikan*) to whose totality the fragments promised access (Ōtsuka 2010 [1989]). Azuma Hiroki's *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals* (2001) diagnosed a subsequent mutation: postmodern consumers no longer seek the narrative behind the fragments but consume the database of elements directly, recombining affective components without reference to any totality, in a mode of desire Azuma, after Kojève, called "animalization" (Azuma 2009 [2001]). Triple Triad sits exactly at the hinge between the two regimes. Its cards depict the world's monsters, its Guardian Forces and its principal characters; collecting them is Ōtsuka's narrative consumption, an access to the world through its fragments. But Card Mod converts the fragments into items, the items into magic and the magic into attributes, so that the worldview dissolves into a database of exchangeable values and the database into capital. The card game recapitulates in miniature the passage from narrative to database that Azuma would theorize two years later.

The narrative pushes back. Squall's story is the reconstitution, within a world of database and configuration, of what Lyotard called a *petit récit* (Lyotard 1984 [1979]): not a grand narrative of history or emancipation but a small narrative of two persons and a promise. The tension between the junction menu and the love story is the game's central formal antagonism.

1.10 The Junctional Subject

Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* describes desiring-production through three syntheses: the connective, which couples partial objects and flows; the disjunctive, which records production upon a body without organs; and the conjunctive, which produces a subject as a residuum alongside the machine, a subject who discovers itself after the fact in the states through which it passes (Deleuze and Guattari 1977 [1972]). The subject is not the origin of the syntheses but their byproduct. The junction is a conjunctive synthesis in precisely this sense: the self is produced at the coupling of GF, spell and attribute, and recognizes itself only in the output of its configuration.

The chapter can therefore define its central term. The *junctional subject* is a subject constituted at the coupling point of borrowed powers, which pays for capacity with recollection, whose identity is a configuration rather than a history, and whose value is continuously assessed by the institution that issued it the powers it couples. The orphans of the Garden are junctional subjects par excellence. The question the remainder of the thesis pursues follows directly: what, if anything, remains of a subject when its memory has been converted into power, its origin into a loop, and its time into a single instant? The answer, deferred to Chapter Seven, is that what remains is not something the subject possesses but something another holds for it.



CHAPTER TWO

Liberi Fatali

Orphanhood, Inclosing Reserve, and the Parenthetical Self

Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel, ein aus sich rollendes Rad, eine erste Bewegung, ein heiliges Ja-sagen.

Innocence is the child, and forgetfulness, a new beginning, a game, a self-rolling wheel, a first movement, a holy Yea.

NIETZSCHE, ALSO SPRACH ZARATHUSTRA I

SQUALL Leonhart is the series' first protagonist whose interiority is a formal device rather than a theme: his unspoken thoughts, rendered in parentheses beside his laconic speech, make the gap between inner and outer life the medium of the story, and the narrowing of that gap its plot. This chapter reads that device and the psychology it encodes, situates both in the Japanese discourses of dependence, moratorium and withdrawal that surrounded the game's production, and traces Squall's trajectory from a Heideggerian toward a Watsujian self.

2.1 The Parenthesis as Form

The game's dialogue windows distinguish two registers of Squall's discourse. Spoken lines are often clipped to the point of refusal; the localization's "...Whatever" became a byword. Parenthetical thoughts, anxious, sardonic and self-justifying, are visible to the player and invisible to every other character. The device produces a structural dramatic irony, in which the player knows at every moment what Squall declines to say, and it makes interiority not a hidden depth awaiting discovery but a continuous parallel channel, a second soundtrack running beneath the first.

Bakhtin's analysis of Dostoevsky illuminates the parenthetical voice. Dostoevsky's heroes, Bakhtin argued, speak with a "sideward glance" at an anticipated interlocutor, and their words contain a "loophole," a reserved possibility of altering their final meaning, so that every self-description is hedged against the other's judgment (Bakhtin 1984 [1929/1963]). Squall's parentheses are loophole words: they anticipate how others will see him and preempt them, often by contempt. Vygotsky's account of inner speech as abbreviated, predicative and saturated with personal sense (Vygotsky 1986 [1934]) describes their texture, elliptical and addressed to no one. Their literary ancestor is the narrator of Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864), whose hyperconscious inwardness coexists with paralysis and with a spiteful refusal of sympathy. Their Japanese ancestor is the Sensei of Natsume Sōseki's *Kokoro* (1914), for whom loneliness is the price of having been born into an age of freedom, independence and self-assertion.

The parenthesis has a plot. Across the game the gap between parenthetical and spoken speech narrows, and the decisive moment of narrowing is formally exact. On the Horizon Bridge between Fishermen's Horizon and Esthar, Squall carries the comatose Rinoa on his back and voices aloud, for the first time, the kind of longing he has hitherto confined to parentheses: that he wants to see her smile and hear her voice again. But he speaks to someone who cannot hear. His first fully disclosed speech is *apostrophe*, the figure Jonathan Culler analyzed as the lyric's invocation of an absent or unresponsive addressee, a turning away from the empirical listener by which the speaker constitutes himself as a voice (Culler 1981). Squall becomes a speaker by addressing an absence. The structure anticipates the ending, in which the absent addressee will return to answer.

2.2 Inclosing Reserve: Kierkegaard and the Demonic Shut-Upness of "Whatever"

Kierkegaard's *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844) defines the demonic, in one of its aspects, as *Indesluttethed*, "inclosing reserve" or shut-upness: anxiety about the good, a self that closes itself against communication and freedom, that is "unfreely disclosed," and that reveals itself only involuntarily, in "the sudden" (Kierkegaard 1980a [1844]). The demonic in this sense is not evil but enclosure, the self's refusal of the disclosure through which it could be freed. Squall's shut-upness is drawn with clinical exactness. When Quistis, his former instructor, seeks him out at night in the Training Center's secret area to confide her own disappointment, he rebuffs her with the suggestion that she take her troubles to a wall. The scene is not cruelty but enclosure: he fears the claim another's disclosure would make upon him.

The Sickness unto Death (1849) refines the diagnosis. Despair is the misrelation of the self to itself; it ranges from the despair of not willing to be oneself to the defiant despair of willing to be oneself, a self that would rather remain itself in torment than accept help (Kierkegaard 1980b [1849]). Squall's "Whatever" is the phatic signature of despair: neither assent nor refusal, it is a refusal to decide that is itself a decision, a speech act whose content is the withdrawal of content. It is also the linguistic form of the moratorium (2.6). It defers.

2.3 The Porcupines' Winter: Schopenhauer, *Evangelion*, and the Hedgehog's Dilemma

In *Parerga and Paralipomena* (1851), Schopenhauer tells of porcupines who huddle together on a cold winter's day to avoid freezing, are driven apart by their quills, and are driven together again by the cold, until they discover a moderate distance at which they can tolerably exist: the social distance of politeness (Schopenhauer 1974 [1851], vol. 2, §396). *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) gave the parable its contemporary Japanese currency, titling an episode after the "hedgehog's dilemma" and making it the emblem of Shinji Ikari's conviction that intimacy is inseparable from injury. Squall is a hedgehog in this sense: his distance is armor against the pain that closeness has already caused.

The comparison is genealogically plausible and philosophically exact. Both are late-1990s Japanese narratives of adolescent withdrawal whose climax confronts the hero with a totalizing collapse of difference. In *Evangelion*'s Human Instrumentality Project, the barriers between individual souls dissolve and humanity merges into a single being; Shinji finally refuses the fusion, choosing the painful separateness of individuated existence. In *Final Fantasy VIII*, Time Compression threatens to dissolve the boundaries between moments into a single instant owned by a single will; Squall survives it by holding to an appointment. The difference between the two refusals is the difference between the works. Shinji refuses fusion for the sake of individuation, and *The End of Evangelion* (1997) leaves him on a ruined shore beside a hostile other. Squall refuses compression

for the sake of a rendezvous, and the game leaves him in a field of flowers beside a beloved. Where *Evangelion* affirms the separation of the Two as a wound, *Final Fantasy VIII* affirms it as a place.

2.4 Amae Refused: Doi, Winnicott, Bowlby, and the Child in the Rain

The psychoanalyst Doi Takeo proposed in *The Anatomy of Dependence* (1971) that *amae*, the wish to presume upon another's benevolence and to be passively loved, is a key to Japanese psychology, and that its frustration underlies a range of disturbances (Doi 1973 [1971]). Doi's culturalist claims have been justly criticized as a species of *nihonjinron*, the discourse of Japanese uniqueness, but the concept remains descriptively powerful. Squall's founding trauma is a frustration of amae: as a small child at the orphanage he waited in the rain for the return of the older girl he called "Sis," Ellone, who had been taken away, and resolved thereafter to depend upon no one. His self-sufficiency is a renunciation of amae as a defense against its frustration. Rinoa, by contrast, practices amae openly: she asks, presumes, claims, enlists him in her causes and demands his protection. The relationship is, in Doi's terms, the education of a man who cannot presume into one who can be presumed upon, and who can at the end permit himself to be found.

Winnicott's paradox that the capacity to be alone rests on the experience of being alone in the presence of another, classically the mother whose reliable presence allows the infant to forget her (Winnicott 1965 [1958]), clarifies the difference between Squall's aloneness and its healthy counterpart. His is not capacity but defense, the solitude of a false self organized to protect a true self that found its environment unreliable. Bowlby's attachment theory would classify the pattern as avoidant, a strategy of deactivating attachment needs after repeated separation (Bowlby 1969–80). Freud's account of his grandson's *fort/da* game, in which the child masters his mother's departures by throwing a spool away and reeling it back (Freud 1955 [1920]), offers a structural key. The child in the rain is caught in a *fort* without *da*; the adult's refusal of attachment preempts any *da* by refusing to let anything be thrown. The ending completes the movement. The *da* arrives, but not because Squall reels it in: the other returns of her own accord, to a place.

The maternal series behind the trauma is triple. Raine, his mother, died while Laguna was absent; Ellone, the substitute sister-mother, was taken; Edea, the Matron, was lost to possession and then to forgetting. Squall has lost the mother three times, to death, to departure and to amnesia. The family's onomastics compound the pattern into something close to allegory: *Squall*, a sudden violent storm, is born of *Raine* and of *Laguna*, a lagoon, and as a child he waits for his sister in the rain. Both protagonists, moreover, bear surnames the game's materials associate with their mothers. Rinoa uses Julia's surname, Heartilly, rather than that of her estranged father, General Caraway, and Leonhart is generally attributed to Raine's line. Both names carry a heart.

2.5 Splitting the Matron: Klein and the Depressive Position

Melanie Klein distinguishes the paranoid-schizoid position, in which the infant splits the mother into an idealized good object and a persecutory bad one, from the depressive position, in which the infant recognizes that the loved and the hated mother are one person, experiences guilt for its aggression and seeks reparation (Klein 1975a [1946]; 1975b [1940]). The game dramatizes the sequence with diagrammatic fidelity. The orphans first fight the Sorceress as a pure persecutor; they then learn that she is the Matron who raised them, a depressive revelation that produces anguish and guilt; they then learn that Edea was possessed by Ultimecia, which re-splits the object, externalizing the bad mother into a figure from the future and restoring the good mother to innocence. The final test of integration concerns not the mother but the beloved. Rinoa inherits sorcery and becomes, in the world's eyes and potentially in fact, the bad object. Squall's vow to remain her knight even if the world turns against her is Kleinian reparation: love directed at an object known to contain the capacity for destruction.

Erich Neumann's Great Mother, with its nurturing and terrible aspects (Neumann 1955), and Kawai Hayao's argument that Japanese culture is organized by a "maternal principle" of containment and inclusion against a "paternal principle" of cutting and distinction (Kawai 1988 [1982]), supply the cultural frame. The Garden is a maternal institution disguised as a military school: it contains, nourishes and protects its orphaned children, and was in fact founded by their Matron. Its headmaster is a weak and conciliatory father who abdicates authority to Squall at the first crisis.

2.6 The Moratorium Institution: Erikson, Okonogi, Saitō, and the Garden as Castalia

Erik Erikson's "psychosocial moratorium," the socially sanctioned delay in which the adolescent may experiment with roles before committing to an adult identity (Erikson 1968), received a Japanese inflection from the psychoanalyst Okonogi Keigo, whose *The Age of the Moratorium People* (1978) diagnosed a generation that prolonged the moratorium indefinitely and refused the commitments of adulthood (Okonogi 1978). The Garden is the moratorium institutionalized: a residential academy in which teenagers train for war as a kind of examination, insulated from society, ranked but not yet committed, under the protection of a hidden mother. Saitō Tamaki's study of *hikikomori*, the social withdrawal of young people into their rooms, appeared in 1998, while the game was in development (Saitō 2013 [1998]). Squall is an emotional *hikikomori* who withdraws not spatially but discursively, into the parenthesis.

The moment of production places the game at a hinge in Japanese cultural history. Two events of 1995 are commonly read as ending the postwar sense of safety. On 17 January, the Great Hanshin earthquake killed more than six thousand people in and around Kobe. On 20 March, members of the religious movement Aum Shinrikyō, acting on the orders of its founder Asahara Shōkō, released the nerve agent sarin on several Tokyo subway trains, killing thirteen people and injuring thousands. Murakami Haruki's *Underground*, built from interviews with victims and then with members of the movement, is the period's literary record of the attack (Murakami 2000

[1997–98]). The attack bears on this argument because Aum justified its violence by an imminent apocalypse it sought to hasten, what Robert Jay Lifton called an attempt to force the end (Lifton 1999), the logic that Chapter Five finds secularized in Ultimecia. Uno Tsunehiro's account of the imagination of the 2000s describes a shift from the 1990s fantasy of withdrawal, epitomized by Shinji's refusal to pilot, to the "decisionism" of survival narratives, in which characters must choose and fight in a world without guarantees (Uno 2008). *Final Fantasy VIII* stands on the hinge. Cid's abdication thrusts leadership upon Squall without his consent: he is compelled to decide. But what he finally decides for is not a Schmittian distinction between friend and enemy. It is a rendezvous.

The literary comparisons are illuminating. Thomas Mann's *The Magic Mountain* (1924) sets its education in a sanatorium where time dilates and Hans Castorp suspends his entry into adult life. Hermann Hesse's *The Glass Bead Game* (1943) imagines Castalia, a pedagogical province devoted to a supreme game synthesizing all culture, which its greatest master must finally leave. Goethe's *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship* (1795–96) reveals that its hero's apparently contingent education was guided throughout by the secret Society of the Tower. The Garden combines all three: a moratorium in which time is suspended, a province organized around a game (combat, and its miniature, Triple Triad), and an institution whose ordinary pedagogy conceals a secret purpose, the training of SeeD against the sorceress. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) offers the darkest homology. Hailsham is a boarding school for children cloned so that their vital organs can be removed, in a series of operations the novel calls "donations," until they die in early adulthood, an outcome it calls "completing." The program is accepted by the society that receives the organs, and the school's guardians nurture the children's health and art while concealing for as long as they can what the children are for. The students cherish the rumor that couples who can prove they are truly in love may receive a "deferral"; when two of them finally ask, the school's former head and its patron tell them that no deferral ever existed. The homology with the Garden is exact and should not be blurred: both institutions take children without parents, prepare them through a pastoral pedagogy, and deliver them to a use that may cost their lives, the battlefield in one case and the operating table in the other. In Ishiguro, love cannot defer the institution's time. *Final Fantasy VIII* wagers that it can, though only by transforming what time is.

2.7 Camel, Lion, Child: The Nietzschean Metamorphoses of Squall Leonhart

The first discourse of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* describes three metamorphoses of the spirit. The spirit becomes a camel, which kneels to be loaded with the heaviest burdens and hastens into the desert beneath them. In the loneliest desert the camel becomes a lion, which would seize its freedom and be master of its own desert; it confronts the great dragon whose every scale glitters with "Thou shalt" and answers "I will," yet the lion cannot create new values, only the freedom for creation. The lion must therefore become a child: innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-propelled wheel, a first movement, a sacred Yes (Nietzsche 2006 [1883]).

Squall's development is these metamorphoses. He begins as the camel, the obedient cadet who bears the Garden's burdens, sits its examinations and accepts its missions without question. He becomes the lion, as his surname, ring and emblem announce, and his "Whatever" and refusal of dependence are the lion's "I will" against the dragon of others' claims. The game concludes by passing beyond the lion. In the final battle, Ultimecia materializes the lion of Squall's imagination as a monstrous adversary, and he must destroy it (Chapter Six); in the sequence that follows, he finds himself at the orphanage of his childhood, in the presence of his child-self; and the closing cinematic ends, for the first time in the game, on his smile. The forgetting the Guardian Forces imposed as instrumental amnesia is transfigured into the child's innocent forgetting, the precondition of a new beginning. The sacred Yes is a smile.

2.8 The Mirror-Rival: Seifer as Shadow, Quixote, and Hegelian Counterpart

The game opens with a duel. In the cinematic prologue, Squall and Seifer Almasy fight with gunblades and wound one another across the face, leaving diagonal scars that mirror each other. Lacan's account of the mirror stage, in which the ego forms through identification with a specular image and is accompanied from the outset by aggressivity toward the double that both founds and threatens it (Lacan 2006 [1949]), describes their bond: each is the other's image and rival. Hegel's struggle for recognition, in which self-consciousness achieves itself only by risking life in a struggle to the death for the other's acknowledgment (Hegel 1977 [1807], §§178–196), is staged in the duel and inscribed in the scars, which function as marks of mutual recognition. Erich Auerbach's celebrated chapter on the scar by which Odysseus's nurse recognizes him (Auerbach 1953 [1946]), together with Aristotle's ranking of recognition by signs as the least artful kind (*Poetics* 1454b), suggests a further point. The scars are recognition tokens of the most external kind; the game's ultimate recognition, between Squall and Rinoa, will occur by no sign at all (Chapter Seven).

Seifer is also Squall's Jungian shadow, the repressed and disowned counterpart of the ego (Jung 1959 [1951]): brash where Squall is withdrawn, romantic where Squall is skeptical, performatively cruel where Squall is privately anxious. Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), whose hero must pursue and finally name the shadow he unleashed, which bears his own name, supplies the narrative paradigm. But Seifer's most precise literary ancestor is Don Quixote. Seifer calls his ambition to serve as a sorceress's knight his "romantic dream," and he realizes it by becoming the knight of the possessed Edea. René Girard's theory of mimetic desire holds that desire is not spontaneous but mediated by a model, as Quixote's is mediated by Amadís of Gaul; the "romantic lie" consists in believing one's desire to be one's own, the "novelistic truth" in recognizing its mediation (Girard 1965 [1961]). Seifer's desire is mediated by the romance of knighthood itself, a role the game also stages as performance in one of Laguna's dream episodes, in which Laguna is cast as a knight in a film production. Squall's anti-romanticism makes his eventual knighthood the novelistic truth of Seifer's romantic lie: desire mediated not by a model but by a promise. The closing

cinematic reintegrates Seifer comically, fishing at Balamb with his companions Fujin and Raijin, the shadow returned to ordinary life.

2.9 From Ningen to Aidagara: Watsuji's Spatial Correction of Heidegger

Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics begins from the Japanese word for the human being, *ningen*, written with characters meaning "person" and "between," and argues that the human is constitutively both individual and social, existing in and as *aidagara*, betweenness (Watsuji 1996 [1937]). His *Fūdo* (1935) opens with a remarkable autobiographical note: reading *Being and Time* in Berlin in 1927, he was struck by its privileging of temporality as the structure of human existence and by its relative neglect of spatiality, and he set out to show that human existence is spatial, climatic and relational as much as temporal (Watsuji 1961 [1935]).

Squall's development traces a passage from a Heideggerian to a Watsujian self. Heidegger's authentic Dasein achieves itself in anticipatory resoluteness toward death, its "ownmost, non-relational" possibility, which individualizes it out of absorption in the anonymous "they" (Heidegger 1962 [1927], §§27, 53). Squall's early ideal of self-sufficiency is a vernacular version of this non-relational authenticity, stripped of its existential depth. His arc moves toward *aidagara*, a self that exists in the between. And Watsuji's spatial correction of Heidegger anticipates with uncanny exactness the game's resolution of its temporal catastrophe by means of a place, a convergence to which Chapter Seven returns. A caution is warranted. Watsuji's ethics of betweenness has been criticized for subordinating the individual to a totality that culminates in the state. The betweenness the game affirms is dyadic, not national: a minimal *aidagara*, the between of two.



CHAPTER THREE

The Secret *Verabredung*

Laguna, Ellone, and the Hauntology of Inheritance

III

Es besteht eine geheime Verabredung zwischen den gewesenen Geschlechtern und unserem.

There is a secret appointment between the generations past and our own.

BENJAMIN, ÜBER DEN BEGRIFF DER GESCHICHTE, II

THE Laguna sequences are the game's theory of inheritance: by projecting the second generation's consciousness into the first generation's past, they make the relation between generations a relation of shared but unalterable time, in which the past cannot be changed but retains a claim upon the present. This chapter reads the sequences as a structural analogue of the Japanese dream Noh, analyzes their unusual focalization, and situates Ellone's discovery of irreversibility within physics, logic and the ethics of forgiveness, before turning to Benjamin's second thesis on history, from which the thesis takes its central concept.

3.1 Dreaming Another's Past: The Laguna Sequences as Mugen Nō

At intervals across the first three discs, Squall and two companions lose consciousness and wake inside the bodies of Laguna Loire and his comrades Kiros Seagill and Ward Zabac, Galbadian soldiers of some seventeen years earlier. The episodes follow Laguna's evening at the Galbadia Hotel, where he contrives to meet the pianist Julia Heartilly; a disastrous mission at the Centra excavation site, from which he falls into the sea; his convalescence in the village of Winhill, where he lives with Raine and the orphan girl Ellone and patrols against monsters; Ellone's abduction by agents of Esthar; and his journey to Esthar, his rescue of Ellone from Dr. Odine's laboratory and his part in the overthrow of the sorceress Adel, after which he becomes, improbably, Esthar's president. A comic interlude finds him acting in a film. The player controls Laguna, whose ineptitude, from a leg that cramps whenever he is nervous to a habit of losing his way, is rendered as affectionate farce; Squall's consciousness, lodged within, registers bemused irritation.

In the *mugen nō*, the "dream" or "phantasmal" Noh that Zeami Motokiyo perfected in the early fifteenth century, a traveling monk (*waki*) arrives at a place famed in poetry or history and meets a local person who recounts a story attached to it; in the second half the local is revealed as the ghost of a figure from that story, who appears in true form, often in the monk's dream, to reenact the past and seek release from attachment before vanishing at dawn. In *Izutsu*, the ghost of Ariwara no Narihira's wife dances in her dead husband's robe and gazes into a well, seeing his image in her own reflection; in *Atsumori*, the ghost of a young warrior confronts the man who killed him, now a monk; in *Kiyotsune*, a fallen warrior appears in his widow's dream. The Laguna sequences reproduce this structure. Witnesses displaced from their own time enter a past bound to particular places (the hotel, the excavation, Winhill), and the past is reenacted with its unfinished affect intact. The resonance with *Izutsu* is especially striking: a woman who sees a lost lover's image in her own will return in the second generation's repetition of the first.

The inversion is instructive. In the Noh, the ghost seeks release through retelling, and the monk's prayer loosens its attachment. Here the reenactment is engineered by Ellone, who sends witnesses into the past because she hopes to change it, and who must learn the Buddhist lesson the ghost already knows: the past cannot be altered, only witnessed and released. Zeami's treatise *Fūshikaden*, in which the performer's art is figured as a "flower" (*hana*) transmitted from father to son, and in which the flower that is hidden is the true flower, returns in Chapter Seven. Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940), in which a man dreams a son into existence only to discover, walk-

ing unburnt into the fire, that he too is dreamed by another, adds a metaleptic turn: the dreamers of Laguna's past are themselves dreamed by a player.

3.2 Nested Focalization and the Junctioned Witness

Genette's narratology distinguishes zero, internal and external focalization (Genette 1980 [1972]). The Laguna sequences produce a configuration without a place in that taxonomy. The player controls Laguna and perceives through his situation, while Squall's consciousness, a passenger within, occasionally comments; afterward the companions compare what they experienced, Selphie infatuated with the soldier she inhabited through his comrade, Squall exasperated by the man he was. Ellone's gift functions, in effect, as a junction between consciousnesses across time. The result may be called *junctioned focalization*: two perspectives sharing one body and one position without merging, the host unaware of the guest.

Edith Stein's phenomenology of empathy holds that another's experience is given to me in a sui generis act, primordial as my act but non-primordial as to its content: I live another's joy without its being originally mine (Stein 1989 [1917]). Squall's dream access exceeds this limit. He lives Laguna's past primordially, from inside, yet without knowing whose life it is. The sequences thereby constitute a thought experiment on the limits of empathy: what would it mean to live another's experience as one's own without knowing that the other is one's father? The scene in which Squall, irritated, judges Laguna's foolishness from within Laguna's body is the son's unwitting judgment of the father, cast as a problem in the phenomenology of intersubjectivity.

3.3 Ellone's Lesson: Irreversibility, Novikov Consistency, and Arendtian Forgiveness

Ellone discovers that her gift cannot change the past. The implied model of time conforms to the self-consistency principle associated with Igor Novikov in the physics of closed timelike curves: the only histories that occur are those that are globally self-consistent, so that no traveler can produce a paradox (Novikov 1998). David Lewis's analysis of the grandfather paradox reaches the same conclusion by logical means: the time traveler "can" kill his grandfather relative to some facts and "cannot" relative to others, since the grandfather's survival is a fact of the past (Lewis 1976). The past of *Final Fantasy VIII* is fixed; its witnesses can only watch.

The contrast with Kitase's *Chrono Trigger* is total. There, the past is an arena of intervention: the party prevents catastrophes, restores the dead and opens alternative futures. *Final Fantasy VIII* rejects the voluntarist model for a tragic one. Its closest literary homologue is Ted Chiang's "The Merchant and the Alchemist's Gate" (2007), in which travelers through a gate of years learn that past and future cannot be changed, but that knowledge of them can still transform the traveler, opening the way to atonement and forgiveness (Chiang 2019 [2007]).

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* identifies two faculties that redeem action from its predicaments: forgiveness, which releases agents from the irreversibility of what they have done, and promising, which binds the unpredictability of the future, raising islands of security in an

ocean of uncertainty (Arendt 1958, §§33–34). The two faculties correspond to the two halves of the game's temporal ethics. Ellone's lesson concerns irreversibility: the past cannot be undone, only accepted and perhaps forgiven. The flower field concerns unpredictability: the future cannot be known, only promised. The game stages no reconciliation between Squall and Laguna; it withholds even the acknowledgment of paternity. But its closing cinematic shows Laguna, with Kiros, Ward and Ellone, at Raine's grave in Winhill: mourning as the form forgiveness takes when its object is the past itself.

3.4 Benjamin's Thesis II and the Weak Messianic Power of the Son

The second of Walter Benjamin's theses "On the Concept of History" (1940) contains a sentence on which this thesis's central concept depends. There is, Benjamin writes, a secret agreement between past generations and the present one: *Es besteht eine geheime Verabredung zwischen den gewesenen Geschlechtern und unserem.* We have been expected on earth; like every generation before us, we have been endowed with a weak messianic power, to which the past has a claim (Benjamin 1968 [1940], Thesis II). *Verabredung* means an agreement, but more precisely an appointment, a rendezvous. Benjamin's past makes an appointment with the present, which keeps it or fails to.

The Laguna sequences literalize the *Verabredung*. The past, in the person of Laguna, has a claim on the present: his love for Julia, interrupted by war; his lost family in Winhill; the child he never knew. The second generation keeps the appointment, not by changing the past but by realizing what it left unrealized. The son of Laguna and the daughter of Julia complete the encounter their parents abandoned. This is precisely what Benjamin meant by the past's "temporal index" referring it to redemption: not reversal but the fulfillment of possibilities that history foreclosed. Rendezvous ontology, formalized in Chapter Seven, thus has its first originator here. The appointment in the flower field is a *Verabredung* in Benjamin's sense, a rendezvous between generations as well as between lovers. Benjamin's ninth thesis, on the angel of history, returns in Chapter Four.

The gentleness of this inheritance should be registered as a choice, because the logic Benjamin describes can be far harsher. In Octavia E. Butler's *Kindred* (1979), Dana, a Black writer living in Los Angeles in 1976, is pulled repeatedly into antebellum Maryland to save the life of Rufus Weylin, a slaveholder's son who becomes a slaveholder himself and who rapes Alice Greenwood, a free-born Black woman he later enslaves. Dana must keep Rufus alive until the child through whom her own family descends is born, and she returns from her final passage having lost an arm (Butler 1979). Butler gives Novikov consistency its moral horror: the descendant may be compelled to preserve the violence from which she descends. Benjamin knew this. His theses speak of the tradition of the oppressed, for whom the state of emergency is not the exception but the rule, and insist that every monument of culture is also a record of barbarism (Benjamin 1968 [1940], Theses VII–VIII). The past of *Final Fantasy VIII* contains its own barbarism, in Adel's tyranny, the abduction of girls and a war of conquest, but the claim it makes on the second generation is the claim of an interrupted love. The game chooses which appointment its children keep.

3.5 Phantoms and Crypts: Abraham, Torok, and Transgenerational Haunting

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished the *crypt*, in which an unspeakable loss is incorporated and entombed within the ego, from the *phantom*, a gap left in a subject by the secrets of others, transmitted unspoken across generations and returning in the descendant as an alien presence (Abraham and Torok 1994 [1978]). Laguna's secrets (his paternity, his absence at Raine's death, his ignorance of the family he left) are never spoken to Squall. Squall carries them as a phantom, and the dream sequences are the phantom's speech: the father's unspoken past passing through the son.

Derrida's *Specters of Marx* generalized the logic of haunting as *hauntology*, the ontology of what is neither present nor absent, and took for its epigraph Hamlet's cry that the time is out of joint (Derrida 1994 [1993]). Inheritance, Derrida insisted, is never a given but a task: one must filter, sift and criticize what one inherits. *Hamlet* is the paradigmatic text, the son haunted by the father's ghost, who demands that he set the time right. *Final Fantasy VIII* inverts it. Here the father is haunted by the son, whose consciousness inhabits him as a ghost from the future; the son does not hear the father's command but lives the father's life from within. It is *Hamlet* reversed: the time is out of joint because the son haunts the father.

A game released two years after *Final Fantasy VIII* makes Derrida's point its explicit thesis. In Kojima Hideo's *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (2001), the protagonist Raiden learns that the mission he has carried out was an exercise staged by the Patriots, a network of artificial intelligences that governs the flow of information, to test their plan to control what a digital society remembers by deciding which information is preserved and which is buried in noise. Raiden's own past is a wound of the same kind: as a boy he was made a child soldier in the Liberian civil war by Solidus Snake, a history he had suppressed. The game ends with Solid Snake's counsel that what a person passes on is neither genes nor received memes but what one chooses to leave behind. *Metal Gear Solid 2* thus stages the industrialization of tertiary retention that Stiegler feared (1.3), memory curated by an apparatus rather than kept by persons, and answers it as Derrida answered the question of inheritance, as a task of selection rather than a given. *Final Fantasy VIII* belongs to the same problem. Its orphans inherit power from a lineage they did not choose and memory from an institution that erased it, and the one thing no lineage or institution hands them, the promise in the flower field, is chosen.

3.6 Fecundity and the Comic Father: Levinas, Lacan, and Laguna's Leg Cramp

In the final section of *Totality and Infinity*, Levinas describes fecundity as a relation in which the self is transcended without being annihilated: the son is "me and not me," a stranger who is also myself, and paternity opens an infinite time beyond the death of the subject (Levinas 1969 [1961]). Through fecundity the future becomes genuinely other. The game reverses the vector of Levinasian fecundity, since it is the son who lives the father's past rather than the father who lives on in the son. The reversal implies that the relation between generations is reciprocal in its alterity: the father is the son's past as the son is the father's future, and each is "me and not me" to the other.

Lacan's account of the Name-of-the-Father, the signifier that institutes the symbolic order and its law (Lacan 1993 [1955–56]), illuminates the game's withholding. The paternal name is never pronounced. Laguna's paternity is implied by every structural element (the chronology, Raine's death, Squall's age, the visual rhymes between them) and confirmed by none. The father appears instead as farce. Laguna's leg cramps whenever he is nervous, above all in Julia's presence, a symptom in which the body betrays desire, after the manner of what Freud called somatic compliance in hysteria. He is a comic soldier, an improbable president who wanders from his duties, a sovereign without gravity. The game's other fathers complete the portrait: General Caraway, the authoritarian whose daughter repudiates his name; Cid Kramer, the conciliatory headmaster who abdicates. Alexander Mitscherlich's diagnosis of a "fatherless society" (Mitscherlich 1969 [1963]) and Etō Jun's reading of postwar Japanese fiction as a record of the mother's collapse and the father's shame (Etō 1967) frame a world in which paternal authority survives only as absence, comedy, tyranny or abdication.

3.7 The Little Phrase: Julia's Song as Transgenerational Vehicle

In the first dream sequence, Julia confides to Laguna her hope of writing songs; the song she later writes for him becomes the game's love theme, "Eyes on Me," which accompanies the love of the second generation. In Proust's *Swann's Way* (1913), a little phrase from Vinteuil's sonata becomes the "national anthem" of Swann's love for Odette, recurring as the involuntary emblem of a passion, and returns much later, transfigured, in Vinteuil's septet for the narrator. Julia's song has exactly this structure. Composed for an encounter that never became a life, it migrates across a generation to sound for a love that does: the little phrase of the parents becomes the anthem of the children.

The song is also a tertiary retention in Stiegler's sense, a technical memory, recorded and performed again, that transmits affect across time and outlives its singer. Julia, the game's materials indicate, died when Rinoa was still a child; her song survives her as the voice of the past keeping its appointment. Mladen Dolar's analysis of the voice as an object detachable from the body (Dolar 2006) suggests why song is the ideal vehicle of transgenerational desire: it is a voice without a body, available to be inhabited by new bodies. The in-house precursor is the opera sequence of *Final*

Fantasy VI, in which an inset aria about a woman waiting for a soldier gone to war becomes the vehicle of another character's longing.

Andrei Tarkovsky's *Mirror* (1975) gives transgenerational desire its most radical cinematic form. The film moves without chronology through the memories of a narrator who is almost never seen, and it casts one actress, Margarita Terekhova, as both his mother in the 1930s and his former wife in the present, so that the son's memory of the mother and his failed marriage wear the same face. Into these memories Tarkovsky cuts newsreels of history, among them Soviet soldiers wading across the Sivash in 1943 and Spanish children evacuated during the Civil War, so that private recollection and collective catastrophe interpenetrate, while his father's poems are read on the soundtrack. Tarkovsky later described cinema as sculpting in time, the shaping of duration itself (Tarkovsky 1986). *Mirror* is the road *Final Fantasy VIII* declines. The game too interleaves a war, the Sorceress War of Laguna's generation, with a private love, and it too lets the first generation's woman echo in the second's, through Julia's song in Rinoa's story. But it never gives them one face. Rinoa is not Julia's double, and Squall never meets the woman his father loved. The song migrates; the person does not. That difference keeps the second generation's love from being a mere repetition of the first.

3.8 Winhill as Idyll: Bakhtinian Chronotopes of the First Generation

Bakhtin's theory of the chronotope, the intrinsic connectedness of temporal and spatial relations in literature, distinguishes several types (Bakhtin 1981 [1937–38]). In the Greek adventure novel, lovers are separated and subjected to trials across vast spaces, but adventure-time leaves no trace: they emerge unchanged. In the idyll, life is bound to a particular place, and the unity of place across generations softens the temporal boundaries between individual lives, linking cradle and grave, childhood and old age, in a cyclical rhythm. The picaresque follows its hero along the road through episodes that alter his station but not his nature.

Laguna is a picaresque hero: soldier, aspiring journalist, film actor, rebel and president in succession, he rises to sovereignty by accident and without inner transformation. Winhill, where he lives with Raine and Ellone in a small village of flowers and patrols, is the first generation's idyll, and its destruction (Ellone's abduction, Laguna's departure, Raine's death) is the expulsion from which the second generation's orphanhood follows. The love story of Squall and Rinoa borrows the Greek romance's structure of separation and reunion but violates its law, since these lovers are changed by their trials. And the game's final place, the flower field beside the orphanage, reconstitutes the idyll in a new mode: a place where generations (Edea young and old, Squall child and adult) coexist without collapsing into one. Chapter Seven names this mode the promissory chronotope.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Succession of Witches

Sorcery, Containment, and the Angel–Witch Dialectic

IV

Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live.

EXODUS 22:18, AUTHORIZED VERSION

SORCERY in *Final Fantasy VIII* is a matrilineal inheritance that the world's institutions cannot abolish and therefore seek to contain, and the game's gender politics turn on whether the knight who guards the sorceress is her jailer or her ally. This chapter reconstructs the mythology of sorcery, reads its central relic and its carceral institution, examines the iconography of angel and witch and the onomastics of the two great sorceresses, and identifies the persecutory circuit, the witch-loop, that the game's ending interrupts.

4.1 Hyne's Scattered Body: The Mythology of Sorcery

The game's mythology attributes sorcery to Hyne, a legendary sorcerer-creator whose power, divided and dispersed in the aftermath of his conflict with the humanity he made, survives in a lineage of sorceresses. Three rules govern the lineage as the game presents it: sorcery passes among women; a sorceress cannot die until she has transferred her power to a successor; and the powers of several sorceresses can accumulate in one. The history of the world is in large part the history of this succession and of the institutions that have sought to control it: the Sorceress War, during which Esthar's Adel waged expansionist war while searching for a young successor, which is why her agents abducted girls, Ellone among them; Adel's overthrow and sealing in an orbital tomb by the rebellion Laguna joined; Galbadia's alliance with Edea; and Esthar's Sorceress Memorial, a facility for sealing sorceresses in which Rinoa will request her own confinement.

The myth has Gnostic resonances. In the Valentinian systems reconstructed by Hans Jonas, fragments of divine *pneuma* are scattered in matter after a primordial catastrophe, and the drama of salvation is the regathering of the sparks; in some versions the catastrophe originates in the passion of Sophia, a female aeon whose desire generates the deficient world (Jonas 1958). Hyne's dispersed power, borne by women, is a pneumatic inheritance of this kind: divinity carried in fragments by a lineage the material order fears. The Lurianic Kabbalah's image of the breaking of the vessels and the scattering of sparks offers a second analogue. In both, a dispersed divinity awaits regathering, and Ultimecia's Time Compression may be read as a demonic regathering, an attempt to unite not the sparks but the moments, under a single will.

4.2 Lunatic Pandora: Hesiod, Epimetheus, and the Hope That Remains

The Lunatic Pandora, a colossal relic structure that draws down the Lunar Cry, the periodic rain of monsters from the moon that destroyed the ancient Centra civilization, is the site of the game's penultimate confrontation, in which Rinoa, absorbed into the body of the freed Adel, must be separated from her. Its name joins two fields of meaning. *Luna* evokes the moon and lunacy, the old association of the lunar with madness and with the feminine. *Pandora* is the first woman of Hesiod's poems, fashioned by the gods as a "beautiful evil" (*kalon kakon*) to punish humanity for Prometheus's theft of fire, given as wife to Epimetheus despite his brother's warning, and the opener of the jar from which evils scattered across the earth, leaving only Hope (*Elpis*) within (*Theogony* 570–612; *Works and Days* 42–105).

The convergences are dense. Pandora is the misogynist mytheme par excellence, woman as container of evil, and the Lunatic Pandora is literally a container of evils associated with the moon. Pandora is given to Epimetheus, the god of afterthought whose forgetting Stiegler made the origin of technics (1.3), so that the lunar reliquary closes a circle with the Guardian Forces' Epimethean amnesia. And Hope remains in the jar: Rinoa, held within Adel within the Lunatic Pandora, is the *Elpis* the container still holds when every evil has escaped. Theocritus's second *Idyll*, the *Pharmakeutria*, in which a woman invokes the moon to work a love-spell that will draw her lover back, supplies a classical precedent for the alliance of the lunar, the sorceress and the beloved's return. The waltz to which Squall and Rinoa first dance is named for the moon.

4.3 Confinement: Michelet, Federici, Foucault, and the Sorceress Memorial

Jules Michelet's *La Sorcière* (1862) revalued the witch as the medieval people's rebel against feudal and ecclesiastical order, a healer and heretic whose persecution was a persecution of nature and of women (Michelet 1862). The history behind that revaluation should be stated plainly. Between roughly 1450 and 1750, secular and ecclesiastical courts in Europe and its colonies tried tens of thousands of people for witchcraft and executed an estimated forty to sixty thousand, a large majority of them women, frequently on confessions extracted by torture (Levack 2016). The persecution had theorists. The *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486–87), written chiefly by the Dominican inquisitor Heinrich Kramer, supplied a doctrine that defined witchcraft as predominantly female, prescribed the procedures by which witches were to be found, and authorized the means by which they were made to confess (Kramer 1486–87): a manual for identifying witches became an instrument for producing them. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) reads the hunts as a constitutive moment of primitive accumulation, through which women's bodies and reproductive capacities were subjected to state and capital and the category of the witch was manufactured to discipline women who controlled their own powers (Federici 2004). Foucault's history of the "great confinement" of the mad (Foucault 2006 [1961]), and his broader account of disciplinary sequestration, describe the institutional form: deviance enclosed, studied and managed.

One onomastic coincidence deserves record, whether or not it was intended. The headmaster who directs the institution created to defeat the sorceress is Cid Kramer, and the sorceress who founded it with him is Edea Kramer. The married name of the game's founding couple is the name of the principal author of the most notorious manual of witch-hunting in European history. The witch-loop of 4.8 is inscribed in a marriage.

The Sorceress Memorial is this apparatus rendered as science fiction: a facility in which sorceresses are sealed in suspended animation, the object of Dr. Odine's research, a containment of female power as public hazard. Its most disturbing moment is voluntary. After the events in space, Rinoa, fearing what she has become and what she might do, asks to be sealed. The scene stages what Foucault described as the internalization of the disciplinary gaze and what Beauvoir described as woman's adoption of the masculine perspective upon herself as Other: the sorceress consents to her confinement because she has learned to see herself as the world sees her. Squall's breaking of the seal, carrying Rinoa out of the facility against Esthar's will, is at once liberation and recapture, and the ambiguity is the subject of the rest of this chapter.

Three homologues frame the scene. In the *Kojiki* (712), Izanagi descends to the underworld to retrieve his dead wife Izanami, breaks her prohibition against looking at her, sees her decomposing body, flees, and seals the passage between the worlds with a great boulder: the first sealed woman of Japanese myth, confined by the man who loved her. Kawai Hayao's reading of the Japanese tale-type of the woman who disappears once a man violates a prohibition on looking (Kawai 1988 [1982]) shows how persistently Japanese narrative associates the feminine with what must not be seen and must therefore be closed off. In Le Guin's *The Tombs of Atuan* (1971), the priestess Tenar, consecrated from childhood to the service of a labyrinth, is led out by the wizard Ged. And

in Ueda Fumito's *Ico* (2001), a girl is imprisoned by her mother, a sorceress queen who intends to inhabit her daughter's body and so prolong her own life, a structure of maternal possession strikingly close to Ultimecia's possession of the sorceresses of the past.

4.4 The Angel in the House and the Madwoman in the Castle

Simone de Beauvoir argued that woman has been constituted as man's Other, and that the myths of femininity oscillate between opposed images serving a single function: the Virgin and the Witch, the angel and the demon, the Mother who gives life and the Mother who devours (Beauvoir 2009 [1949]). Coventry Patmore's *The Angel in the House* (1854–62) codified the Victorian ideal of selfless domestic femininity that Virginia Woolf, in "Professions for Women," declared it necessary to kill (Woolf 1942). Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar read nineteenth-century women's writing through the paired images of angel and monster, arguing that the madwoman in the attic, Bertha Mason in *Jane Eyre*, is the angel's double, the rage the ideal suppresses (Gilbert and Gubar 1979).

The game's iconography reproduces this structure with remarkable precision. Rinoa is figured as an angel: white wings appear in the opening cinematic, a feather drifts through the beginning and the end, and as a sorceress her Limit Break is called Angel Wing. Ultimecia is the dark-winged sorceress enthroned in a castle at the end of time, the madwoman's attic expanded into a fortress. The hypothesis that Rinoa becomes Ultimecia, examined in Chapter Eight, literalizes Gilbert and Gubar's thesis: the angel and the madwoman are one woman, separated by time.

Benjamin's ninth thesis offers a counter-image. Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus*, Benjamin writes, shows an angel who seems about to move away from something he contemplates; this is the angel of history, his face turned toward the past, where he sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage. He would stay and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught his wings and propels him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned; this storm is what we call progress (Benjamin 1968 [1940], Thesis IX). Rinoa's wings may be read as the angel of history's. Her face turned toward the wreckage of occupied Timber and her father's wars, she is blown backward into a future in which she will bear the sorceress's power. Ultimecia would then be the angel who has turned around, facing the storm's destination and seeking to halt it by compressing all its moments into one.

Julia Kristeva's account of the abject, that which must be expelled for the subject to constitute its borders and which returns as horror, with its privileged association with the maternal body (Kristeva 1982 [1980]), and Barbara Creed's analysis of the "monstrous-feminine," in which the witch and the archaic mother figure terror at female generative power (Creed 1993), explain why sorcery in the game is at once sublime and abject. Hélène Cixous and Catherine Clément's *The Newly Born Woman* (1975) pairs the sorceress and the hysteric as figures of feminine revolt occupying the margins of the symbolic order. Clément, in "The Guilty One," argues that both are ultimately reintegrated, their disorder recuperated; Cixous, in her contribution to the volume and in "The Laugh of the Medusa," imagines an escape (Cixous and Clément 1986 [1975]; Cixous 1976

[1975]). Rinoa's trajectory, from sorceress to sealed sorceress to reintegrated beloved, enacts Clément's pessimism. Whether it also holds Cixous's laughter is the question of 4.9.

4.5 (M)Edea: Maternal Sorcery and the Good Mother Possessed

The name of the sorceress who founded the Garden is *Medea* without its initial letter. Medea, in Euripides' tragedy (431 BCE), is the archetypal sorceress: granddaughter of Helios, helper of Jason, murderer of her own children when Jason abandons her. Whether or not the resemblance was intended, Edea functions as Medea's inversion. She is a maternal sorceress whose infanticidal potential is displaced, onto possession by Ultimecia and onto a future in which her children must fight her, and she answers that potential not by enacting it but by preempting it: with Cid, she founds an institution that trains her children to defeat her should she become their enemy. In the final sequence she accepts the dying Ultimecia's power precisely so that it will not pass to a child. Where Medea kills her children to wound their father, Edea takes the curse into herself to spare them. Cid, faithful and conciliatory, is Jason inverted.

The Kleinian reading of 2.5 acquires here its mythic dimension. The good mother possessed by the bad, the mother forgotten by her children and then remembered, the mother who builds the instrument of her own defeat: Edea is the game's most complex figure of maternal ambivalence, and her name inscribes, by subtraction, the catastrophe she prevents.

4.6 Arutimishia: Onomastics of the Final Sorceress

The final antagonist's Japanese name, アルティミシア (Arutimishia), is a transliteration conventionally associated with *Artemisia*; the English localization rendered it as Ultimecia, foregrounding an etymology of finality (*ultima*, the last). The two names encode two readings of the figure. The localization's reading is eschatological: she is the last sorceress at the end of time. The original's is mythic and elegiac, and its polysemy is extraordinary. *Artemisia* derives from Artemis, virgin huntress and goddess of the moon: the hunter who is also hunted, the lunar power around which the game's Lunar Cry and Lunatic Pandora orbit. Artemisia II of Caria built the Mausoleum at Halicarnassus for her husband Mausolus and was said to have drunk his ashes in her grief, becoming the classical archetype of inconsolable mourning; the name thus holds the grief the final battle will literally embody (Chapter Six). Artemisia I of Caria, whom Herodotus describes commanding ships at Salamis (*Histories* VIII), is the archetype of the woman at war. *Artemisia* is also the botanical genus of wormwood and mugwort, plants of bitterness, and in the Revelation of John a great star called Wormwood falls from heaven burning like a lamp and makes a third of the waters bitter (Revelation 8:10–11): a falling star, in a game whose lovers first meet beneath one.

Artemisia Gentileschi, the Baroque painter of *Judith Slaying Holofernes*, carries a history the name's other bearers do not. In 1611 she was raped by the painter Agostino Tassi, a colleague of her father engaged to teach her perspective. At the trial her father brought in Rome in 1612, she was questioned under torture with thumbscrews to test the truth of her testimony; Tassi was con-

victed and sentenced to exile from Rome, a sentence that was never enforced. Her paintings of Judith beheading Holofernes have been read against this history since Mary Garrard's study, as images of female retribution (Garrard 1989), though art historians have cautioned against reducing them to autobiography. The detail bears on this chapter's argument. A court that tortured the woman in order to believe her is a small instance of the procedure the witch trials made systematic, in which an institution's violence against women is the means by which it decides what women are.

These resonances are offered as onomastic overdetermination, not authorial intention. Taken together, however, they suggest that the final sorceress is less a villain than a convergence of the game's feminine figures: huntress and hunted, mourner and warrior, falling star and bitter flower. Through her original name, the final sorceress and the flower field are botanical kin.

4.7 The Knight: Courtly Love, Quixotic Romance, and the Prince Who Would Save

The game's lore pairs a sorceress with a knight who protects her, and the role is the hinge of its gender politics. Its genealogy runs through the courtly love of Andreas Capellanus's *De amore* (c. 1185) and Chrétien de Troyes's *Lancelot, or the Knight of the Cart* (c. 1177–81), in which the knight accepts humiliation in his lady's service, to Denis de Rougemont's argument that Western passion, epitomized by Tristan and Iseult, loves the obstacle and secretly desires death (Rougemont 1983 [1939]). Seifer's knighthood is passion in de Rougemont's sense: he serves the sorceress's power, embraces the obstacle of the world's enmity, and pursues his romantic dream to the edge of self-destruction. What that service involves should be named. As the possessed Edea's knight, Seifer interrogates Squall under electric torture in the D-District Prison, commands the Galbadian assault on Balamb Garden, and later hands Rinoa over to Adel. In his hands the romance of knighthood becomes the enforcement arm of a sovereign power: the knight as torturer.

The knight is also the patriarchal mediation of female power, the protector through whom the dangerous woman is rendered safe, and several works contemporaneous with the game or later subject the figure to a critique that is precise about who harms whom. Ikuhara Kunihiko's *Revolutionary Girl Utena* (1997), made while the game was in development, is set in Ohtori Academy, where students duel for possession of the Rose Bride, Anthy, who is treated as a prize and called a witch. The academy's adult acting chairman, Akio, who styles himself the "End of the World," is revealed as what remains of the prince that the heroine Utena wishes to become. He sexually abuses his sister Anthy and sexually exploits Utena, who is fourteen, while staging the duels to obtain power for himself. In the series' myth, Anthy hid her brother away to spare him the world's endless demand to be rescued, and for this she was branded a witch and condemned to be pierced forever by the swords of the world's hatred. *Utena* thus makes literal what the witch-loop describes: the woman who refuses to sacrifice herself to the rescue fantasy is named a witch and punished, and the prince the fantasy celebrates is the abuser it conceals.

Jonathan Blow's *Braid* (2008) delivers the critique as a reversal of time: its final level, replayed backward, reveals that the princess the hero has been pursuing was fleeing him. Ursula K. Le Guin's *Tehanu* (1990) revisits her own Earthsea, whose school of wizards admitted no women and whose proverbs disparaged women's magic, through Therru, a girl who was raped, beaten and pushed into a fire by her father and his companions, and whom Tenar adopts. The novel ties the male monopoly on magic to men's violence against women and children, and it ends by revealing the most harmed child as the bearer of the deepest power. *Puella Magi Madoka Magica* (2011) makes the succession of witches an industry. The alien Kyubey grants adolescent girls a wish in exchange for their souls, which it removes into gems, without telling them that each will become a witch when her hope turns to despair, at which point it harvests the energy her transformation releases; the magical girls spend their short lives killing witches who were girls before them. The series depicts a witch-loop administered for profit, in which the institution that recruits the hunters manufactures the hunted, and hunters and hunted are the same girls. Its heroine breaks the loop only by rewriting the law of the universe and becoming a principle present at all times, a benevolent counterpart of Ultimecia's compression.

Against this background, Squall's vow at the Sorceress Memorial, that he will remain Rinoa's knight even if the whole world becomes her enemy, must be read with care. It can be heard as possession, the man claiming the dangerous woman as his charge. But its content differs from Seifer's. Seifer serves the sorceress's power; Squall serves the person against the world's fear of her power. Seifer's knighthood is instrumental; Squall's protects her freedom from containment.

4.8 The Witch-Loop: Persecution as Production

The game's bootstrap structure has a political form. SeeD exists to defeat the sorceress. Ultimecia attacks the Gardens because she knows that SeeD will come for her. She possesses Edea, who founded SeeD because a SeeD from the future told her to. Ultimecia's power passes in the past to Edea, Edea's to Rinoa, and Rinoa's future is open but haunted by the iconography of the end. The circuit is a persecution-production loop: the institution created to hunt the witch produces the conditions under which the witch becomes monstrous, and the monstrous witch produces the institution. Robert Merton's analysis of the self-fulfilling prophecy, in which a false definition of a situation evokes behavior that makes the originally false conception come true (Merton 1948), describes its sociology; Federici's account of the witch hunts as the manufacture of the witch describes its history.

The thesis calls this structure the *witch-loop*, and it permits a reinterpretation of Ultimecia. She is less an individual than a *witch-function*, in the sense in which Foucault spoke of an author-function: the name the loop gives to sorcery at the terminal point of its persecution. We learn almost nothing of her history, except that she knows SeeD will come and that she hates it. This is enough. Every sorceress hunted to the end of time becomes Ultimecia. The hypothesis that Rinoa is Ultimecia is therefore structurally true even if it is empirically false: Rinoa is Ultimecia in the precise sense that Ultimecia is what any sorceress becomes if the loop is not broken.

4.9 The Knight Who Does Not Hunt

The only exit from the witch-loop is a member of the hunting institution who refuses to treat a sorceress as an enemy. Squall, a SeeD and by now the leader of SeeD, vows knighthood to a sorceress and breaks her out of the facility built to contain her. He thereby suspends the founding purpose of the institution he leads. Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished law-making from law-preserving violence and both from a "divine" violence that deposes law itself (Benjamin 1978 [1921]). Squall's act is not violent, but it has the structure Benjamin assigned to the deposing of law: a refusal, from within an institution, of that institution's reason for being.

The resolution of the game complicates the feminist critique further. In the final sequence, as Chapter Seven shows, the knight does not rescue the sorceress. He waits, lost and unable to recall her face, at the place he promised, and she finds him. The knight's ultimate role is not intervention but abiding; the sorceress's is seeking. The gender topology of fidelity inherited from Homer, in which Penelope keeps the immovable center while Odysseus wanders, is inverted. *Final Fantasy VIII*'s feminism is partial. The sorceress's power remains conditionally safe, safe in relation, and the knight remains its guarantor. But the partiality is legible as the trace of the loop the game tries to break, and its final image gives the active role to the woman who was nearly sealed away. The knight who does not hunt becomes the knight who waits to be found.



CHAPTER FIVE

Tota Simul

The Theology, Metaphysics, Physics, and Political Economy of Time Compression

Aeternitas igitur est interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio.

Eternity, then, is the whole, simultaneous and perfect possession of unlimited life.

BOETHIUS, DE CONSOLATIONE PHILOSOPHIAE V.6

Time Compression is the game's name for the conversion of all duration into a single instant possessed by a single will, and it condenses four historical discourses on time into one catastrophe: the theology of eternity, the mythology of the devouring father, the metaphysics of presence, and the political economy of late capitalism. This chapter reconstructs each, distinguishes the game's closed loop of origin from the compression that threatens to swallow it, and closes by setting against Ultimecia a tradition, running from Paul to Dōgen and Nishida, in which totality need not mean compression.

5.1 What Ultimecia Wants

From a distant future, Ultimecia projects her consciousness into the sorceresses of the past, exploiting Ellone's gift and its technological imitation. Her aim is to reach a point from which she can compress all of time into a single moment in which only she exists, becoming in effect a god. The compression begins after the confrontation aboard the Lunatic Pandora, under a plan that the heroes, guided by Laguna, Ellone and Dr. Odine, deliberately allow to proceed, so that compressed time will carry them to Ultimecia's era. They are warned that survival in compressed time depends on holding fast to the image of the people and places to which they wish to return; without such an anchor they will be lost. The game thus states its own thesis, in the form of a practical instruction, before its final act: when chronology dissolves, only a place and a person can orient the self.

Compression must be distinguished from destruction. Ultimecia does not seek to annihilate time but to totalize it. Everything is kept, but simultaneously, and for one subject. This distinction governs the reconstruction that follows.

Ultimecia's method has a precedent in the first grand history of the human future. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) traces eighteen successive human species across two billion years and presents itself as the work of two authors: one living in the twentieth century, and one among the Last Men on Neptune, who, facing the destruction of the solar system, can enter the minds of earlier humans and dictate the book through the mind of its earthly author. In its final chapters the Last Men, unable to survive, prepare to scatter the seeds of a new humanity among the stars (Stapledon 1930). Stapledon's future reaches into the past to inspire it; Ultimecia's reaches into the past to possess it. The two share a technique and invert an ethic: a future that writes through the minds of the past may be a muse or a tyrant. That the Last Men's final act is a sowing of seeds, while the institution founded against Ultimecia is called SeeD, is a coincidence, but the kind through which a tradition becomes legible to a later reader.

5.2 Usurping Eternity: Boethius, Aquinas, Augustine

Boethius defines eternity as *interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio*, the whole, simultaneous and perfect possession of unlimited life, and distinguishes it from perpetuity, an unending succession of moments; God's knowledge is accordingly not foreknowledge but a vision of all times as present (*Consolation of Philosophy* V, prose 6). Ultimecia seeks to convert a finite creature's life into Boethian eternity by collapsing succession: she would possess all of time *tota simul*. Her project is a creature's usurpation of the divine mode of being.

Thomas Aquinas distinguished three measures of duration: *aeternitas*, the measure of God's unchanging being; *tempus*, the measure of changing things; and *aevum*, the intermediate measure of beings unchanging in substance but capable of change in their operations, namely the angels (*Summa Theologiae* I, q. 10, a. 5). Frank Kermode proposed that the *aevum* furnishes a model for the time of fictions, a duration neither eternal nor merely successive (Kermode 1967). Rinoa, the winged sorceress, may be read as dwelling in the *aevum*, between time and eternity; Ultimecia as the attempt to collapse the *aevum* into an illegitimate *aeternitas*.

Book XI of Augustine's *Confessions* opens its inquiry with a celebrated aporia: *Quid est ergo tempus? Si nemo ex me quaerat, scio; si quaerenti explicare velim, nescio*, "What then is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know" (XI.14.17). Augustine resolves it by locating time in the soul. There are three presents, the present of things past (memory), the present of things present (attention) and the present of things future (expectation), and time is a *distentio animi*, a distension of the mind stretched among them (XI.20.26; XI.26.33). Compression annihilates the *distentio*: the soul, Ultimecia's, is contracted into a single present that has absorbed memory and expectation alike. In the *City of God*, Augustine attributes the two cities to two loves, the earthly founded on love of self to the contempt of God, the heavenly on love of God to the contempt of self (*City of God* XIV.28). Ultimecia's compression is *amor sui* raised to a cosmic program: love of self to the contempt of every other being and every other moment.

The Luciferian intertext completes the theology. Isaiah's taunt against the king of Babylon, read by Christian tradition as the fall of Lucifer, gives the ambition its form: "I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God ... I will be like the most High" (Isaiah 14:13–14). Milton's Satan proclaims that "The mind is its own place, and in it self / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.254–55). Ultimecia's castle, a fortress outside ordinary time where she reigns alone, is the mind as its own place. Dante names the divine point toward which her ambition strains: the point *là 've s'appunta ogne ubi e ogne quando*, where every where and every when converge (*Paradiso* XXIX.12). Borges's "The Aleph" (1945), a point in a Buenos Aires cellar containing all the points of space, is the secular and spatial inversion. Time Compression would be a temporal Aleph owned by one person.

5.3 Kronos Devouring: Hesiod, Goya, and the Fated Children

In Hesiod's *Theogony*, Kronos, warned that he will be overthrown by one of his children, swallows each as it is born; Rhea hides the infant Zeus, who survives to depose his father (*Theogony* 453–506). Late antiquity and the Renaissance fused Kronos with Chronos, producing the figure of Father Time with his scythe, whose genealogy Erwin Panofsky traced (Panofsky 1939). Goya's *Saturn Devouring His Son*, painted on a wall of his house in the early 1820s, gives the myth its most terrible image.

Ultimecia is Kronos. She knows that SeeD, the children of the future, will come to overthrow her, and she strikes at the Gardens where they are nursed: through the possessed Edea, Galbadia's forces fire missiles that drive Balamb Garden into flight and destroy Trabia Garden, killing students there. The overture's title, "Liberi Fatali," "Fated Children," names the orphans as Kronos's children, destined to depose the devourer; and the overture's choral refrain, whose apparently nonsensical Latinate words resolve by anagram into a phrase concerning the succession of witches and love, encodes the two forces between which the children must pass.

Deleuze's *The Logic of Sense* distinguishes two readings of time. Chronos is the living present, which absorbs past and future into itself, the time of bodies and their mixtures and ultimately of a present that devours. Aion is the infinitely divisible line of the event, an unlimited past and future that sidestep every present, the time of what has always just happened and is always about to happen (Deleuze 1990 [1969]). Compression is Chronos made absolute: a present that has devoured every past and every future. The promise, by contrast, lives in Aion. It is always already made and not yet kept, an event that never coincides with a present. The opposition between Ultimecia and the flower field is the opposition between Chronos and Aion.

5.4 Verweile Doch: Faust, Kant's Perverse End, and the Night in Which All Cows Are Black

Goethe's Faust stakes his soul on a wager: should he ever say to the passing moment *Verweile doch! du bist so schön!*, "Stay, you are so beautiful!", Mephistopheles may claim him (*Faust* I, 1699–1702). Compression is Faust's forbidden utterance made cosmic: the desire to arrest the moment, which Goethe identifies with damnation. The conclusion of *Faust* II, where the Chorus Mysticus declares that *Das Ewig-Weibliche / Zieht uns hinan*, "the eternal feminine draws us upward" (12110–11), suggests a corollary. Rinoa and Ultimecia represent two forms of the eternal feminine as the game imagines it: the drawing-upward that keeps time moving, and the holding-still that would end it.

Kant's late essay "The End of All Things" (1794) distinguishes three ends: the natural end, according to the order of moral purposes; the mystical or supernatural end, in the order of efficient causes, of which we understand nothing; and the contranatural or perverse end, which human beings bring upon themselves by misunderstanding the final end. Kant observes that the thought of a moment at which all alteration ceases, and time with it, is one at which the imagination revolts,

since all nature would then stand petrified (Kant 1996 [1794]). Compression is Kant's perverse end: an end of all things brought about by a will that has misunderstood its purpose.

Hegel's Preface to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* mocks the philosophy of an Absolute in which all distinctions vanish as "the night in which, as the saying goes, all cows are black," insisting against it that the true is the whole only as the process of its becoming, substance that is equally subject (Hegel 1977 [1807], §§16–17). In the *Science of Logic*, Hegel distinguishes the spurious infinite, the endless progression that never reaches its goal, from the true infinite, whose image is the circle, the finite returning to itself through its other (Hegel 2010 [1812–16]). Compression is the night in which all cows are black: an abstract infinite that annihilates the finite and is, as Hegel argued of every such infinite, itself only another finite. The game's founding loop, by contrast, has the shape of the circle, and Chapter Seven argues that it becomes a true infinite only when it includes the rendezvous that exceeds it.

The pre-Socratic genealogy is ancient. Parmenides' Being "now is, all together, one, continuous" (fragment B8), without past or future; Heraclitus's world is a river into which no one steps twice; Zeno's arrow, at rest at every instant, is the paradox of an instant torn from its series. Italo Calvino's story "t zero" (1967) places its narrator, a hunter, at the instant when a lion leaps upon him and his arrow is in flight, and has him reason whether that instant can be detached from the instants that follow (Calvino 1969 [1967]). Compression would realize the Parmenidean One and Zeno's frozen instant, and Calvino's suspended lion anticipates with startling precision the lion Squall will face at the end of time. J. M. E. McTaggart's distinction between the A-series (past, present, future) and the B-series (earlier and later) permits a final specification: compression abolishes the A-series, since nothing passes, and the B-series, since nothing precedes anything else, leaving at most McTaggart's non-temporal C-series, or a point (McTaggart 1908).

Three novels give the arrested instant fictional bodies, and each sharpens what compression would mean. In Murakami Haruki's *Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World* (1985), a scientist's experiment has implanted in the narrator's brain a circuit that, when his ordinary consciousness fails, will lock him into an endless interior moment. That moment is figured as a walled Town at the End of the World, whose inhabitants have had their shadows cut away and their minds drained, and where the narrator reads old dreams from the skulls of unicorns; at the end he chooses to remain in the Town while his shadow escapes (Murakami 1991 [1985]). Murakami gives compression its interior form, an eternity that is a closed mind, entered at the price of memory and shadow, the price the Guardian Forces exact in installments. In J. G. Ballard's *The Crystal World* (1966), time leaks from matter in an African forest, which crystallizes, and some of those caught in it embrace the crystallization as transfiguration: compression as catastrophe and as sublime (Ballard 1966). Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) has its hero, Billy Pilgrim, slip helplessly between the moments of his life and learn from the Tralfamadorians that all moments exist at once, so that death is only one bad moment among many. The novel's center is the firebombing of Dresden by British and American air forces in February 1945, which killed some twenty-five thousand people and which Vonnegut survived as a prisoner of war sheltered in a meat locker beneath a slaughterhouse (Vonnegut 1969). Tralfamadorian simultaneity is a consolatory compression, a vantage from which atrocity can be borne because no moment is ever lost. *Final*

Fantasy VIII refuses that consolation as firmly as it refuses Ultimecia's ambition: the view in which all moments are present at once is the enemy's view, not wisdom's.

5.5 The Metaphysics of Presence as Cosmic Catastrophe

Derrida's critique of Husserl in *Speech and Phenomena* turns on the "blink of an eye" (*Augenblick*) in which consciousness is supposedly present to itself. Husserl's own analysis of time-consciousness shows that the living present is constituted by retention and protention, the just-past and the about-to-come; the present is therefore never simply present but always already divided by traces of what it is not, and absolute self-presence would be death (Derrida 1973 [1967]). *Différance*, at once differing and deferring, names the movement by which every presence is constituted through its relation to absence (Derrida 1982 [1968]). Ultimecia is the metaphysics of presence realized as a cosmic project: the will to absolute self-presence in a single now, without retention, protention or trace. Time Compression is the abolition of *différance*, and the heroes' victory is its reassertion.

Given Time adds a decisive turn. Following Marcel Mauss, for whom the gift entails a term, a delay before the counter-gift, Derrida argues that the gift "gives time": it opens an interval that is the condition both of exchange and of its interruption (Derrida 1992 [1991]; Mauss 1990 [1925]). Compression abolishes the interval; therefore it abolishes the gift; therefore it abolishes the promise, which is a gift of time to another. Bergson's distinction between *durée*, lived qualitative duration, and the spatialized time of clocks (Bergson 1910 [1889]) completes the diagnosis: compression is the ultimate spatialization of time, its reduction to a point.

5.6 Loops Without Origin: Gödel, Novikov, Lewis, and Fabulous Retroactivity

In 1949 Kurt Gödel published solutions to Einstein's field equations describing a rotating universe in which closed timelike curves exist, so that a traveler could in principle return to her own past, and drew the philosophical conclusion that time, in the intuitive sense of an objective lapse, may be ideal rather than real (Gödel 1949a; 1949b; Yourgrau 2005). Novikov's self-consistency principle holds that such loops must be globally consistent (Novikov 1998). David Lewis showed that causal loops in which information has no origin, as when a time traveler gives his younger self the proof of a theorem that the younger self later carries back, are strange but not impossible (Lewis 1976). Robert A. Heinlein's "By His Bootstraps" (1941) and "'—All You Zombies—'" (1959), the latter featuring a person who is his own mother and father, gave the bootstrap paradox its fictional form.

The founding of SeeD is a Lewisian information loop. In the final sequence, Squall, adrift in compressed time, finds himself at the orphanage in the past, witnesses the dying Ultimecia transfer her power to the young Edea, and speaks to Edea of SeeD and the Garden. The institution is founded on information from its own future. Its origin is a quotation.

Derrida's analysis of the American Declaration of Independence describes the political form of this structure. The Declaration is signed in the name of "the people," yet the people does not exist

as a subject before the signature that constitutes it; the signature invents its signer by what Derrida called a "fabulous retroactivity" (Derrida 1986 [1976]). Every foundation, Derrida argued, conceals such a fable; *Final Fantasy VIII* makes the fable literal. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998), in which a linguist who learns to perceive time simultaneously understands that, under foreknowledge, language ceases to be informative and becomes performative, illuminates Squall's words to Edea (Chiang 2002 [1998]). He does not inform her of the future; he enacts it.

The comparanda are extensive. Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (1962) sends a man into the past through his memory of a woman's face and ends on the airport jetty where, as a child, he unknowingly witnessed his own death; Terry Gilliam's *12 Monkeys* (1995) expanded the premise. Christopher Nolan's *Interstellar* (2014) closes its loop when the protagonist becomes the "ghost" his daughter perceived in childhood, within a structure built by future humans. Closest of all is a work released by the same company in the same year. Masato Kato's *Chrono Cross* (1999) ends with the Time Devourer, the fusion of a cosmic parasite with Schala, a young woman of a vanished kingdom. In 1999 Square produced two games whose final threat to time takes the form of a feminine power that would devour it.

5.7 Time-Space Compression: Harvey, Jameson, Virilio, Berardi

The phrase "time compression" has a precise analogue in the critical theory of the game's decade. David Harvey described "time-space compression" as the defining experience of post-Fordist flexible accumulation: the acceleration of turnover time and the annihilation of space by time, with a corresponding vertigo in culture (Harvey 1989). Fredric Jameson diagnosed in postmodernism a waning of historicity and, borrowing Lacan's account of schizophrenia as the rupture of the signifying chain, a temporality dissolved into a sequence of isolated presents (Jameson 1991). Paul Virilio argued that the "real time" of telecommunications annihilates the "deferred time" of reflection and the extension of geography (Virilio 1997 [1995]). Franco Berardi named the slow cancellation of the future (Berardi 2011), and Mark Fisher, extending the phrase, diagnosed a culture haunted by futures that failed to arrive (Fisher 2014) and a capitalist realism in which the end of the world is more readily imagined than the end of capitalism (Fisher 2009). Alexandre Kojève's Hegel declared history ended, and a celebrated note added to the second edition of his lectures identified Japanese "snobbery" as a model of post-historical existence (Kojève 1969 [1947]); Francis Fukuyama gave the claim its post–Cold War form (Fukuyama 1992), and Azuma's database theory took up Kojève's Japan.

Read against this literature, Ultimecia's compression allegorizes the post-historical present: a future that arrives only to cancel futurity, a "now" that absorbs every past and every future into an eternal present of possession. Michael Ende's *Momo* (1973) supplies a strikingly close fable. Grey gentlemen persuade the citizens of a city to deposit their time in a Timesavings Bank, which in fact steals it. Time, Momo learns from Master Hora, takes the form of hour-lilies, flowers that bloom and fade in every human heart, which the grey gentlemen hoard in a vault and smoke in order to survive. Momo defeats them by stopping time and carrying the last hour-lily to free the hoard. In Ende, time is a flower and its enemy is a bank; in *Final Fantasy VIII*, the enemy compresses time

while the heroes are saved by a field of flowers. Both works set a botanical image of time against a financial one.

The Japanese context is specific. The game was released in 1999, the year of the prophecy that Gotō Ben's bestseller *The Great Prophecies of Nostradamus* (1973) had made a fixture of Japanese popular culture: that in the seventh month of 1999 a great king of terror would descend from the sky (Gotō 1973). Millenarian expectation had been central to Aum Shinrikyō's apocalypticism. A game in which monsters rain from the moon and a sorceress from the future seeks to end time appeared in the very year its culture had been taught to expect the sky to fall.

5.8 Kairos Synestalmenos: Paul, Agamben, and the Two Compressions

In the First Letter to the Corinthians, Paul writes *ho kairos synestalmenos estin*, usually rendered "the time is short" (1 Corinthians 7:29). The participle *synestalmenos*, from *systellō*, to draw together, contract, or furl a sail, means literally that the time has been contracted, compressed. Paul draws the consequence: those who have wives should live as though they had none, those who weep as though not weeping, those who buy as though they did not possess, for the form of this world is passing away (7:29–31). Giorgio Agamben reads the passage as the core of messianic time: not the end of time, the eschatological instant at which chronology ceases, but the time of the end, the time that time itself requires in order to end, a contracted time that transforms every relation through the *hōs mē*, the "as not," which revokes every vocation without abolishing it (Agamben 2005 [2000]). From Paul's "remnant" (*leimma*, Romans 11:5), Agamben also derives the concept of a remainder that can never coincide with any whole, the part left over when every division has been made.

The Pauline text permits a decisive distinction between two compressions. Ultimecia's is *sovereign compression*: the totalization of time into one subject's now. Paul's is *messianic contraction*: time drawn together into an urgency that transforms all relations without absorbing them into a single subject. The heroes' passage through compressed time to Ultimecia's castle is messianic in this sense: they live within compression as though not compressed, SeeD who no longer act as SeeD, a knight who does not hunt. The thesis's *inconvertible remainder* is the Pauline remnant: what is left over when the general economy of convertibility has divided and exchanged everything else.

Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) gives the Pauline compression a modern, Gnostic form. Its protagonist, Horselover Fat, a divided double of Dick himself, comes to believe after a visionary experience in 1974 that real time stopped in 70 CE with the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem and resumed only in 1974, so that the intervening centuries are counterfeit and the Roman Empire, in the form of an all-enclosing Black Iron Prison, never ended (Dick 1981). Dick's compression is redemptive: the false time between the apostolic age and the present collapses, and the believer finds himself contemporary with the first Christians. *Final Fantasy VIII* sides against this hope as firmly as against Ultimecia's ambition. Whether the collapse of time promises tyranny or

salvation, the game prefers the ordinary sequence of days, in which a promise can be made in one season and kept in another.

Benjamin's fourteenth thesis opposes the homogeneous, empty time of historicism to *Jetztzeit*, a now-time charged with the past and blasted out of the continuum of history; his fifteenth recalls that on the first evening of fighting in the July Revolution of 1830, insurgents in several parts of Paris independently fired upon the clocks in the towers (Benjamin 1968 [1940], Theses XIV–XV). The first attempt on the sorceress's life in *Final Fantasy VIII* is made from a clock tower above the parade route in Deling City, and the shot fails, stopped by her power: the gesture of the July insurgents inverted, the clock firing upon the agent of compression and failing to halt her. Carl Schmitt's dictum that the sovereign is he who decides on the exception (Schmitt 1985 [1922]) defines Ultimecia's ambition: to be sovereign of time, deciding on the exception of time itself. The thesis names this *compressive sovereignty*. Benjamin's eighth thesis, that for the oppressed the state of emergency is not the exception but the rule, names its consequence: under compression, the exception would be all there is.

5.9 Being-Time: Dōgen, Nishida, Nishitani, and the Non-Compressive Totality

Dōgen's fascicle "Uji" (1240), "Being-Time," argues that being is time and time is being: each moment is complete and contains the whole of time, and the self arrays itself as the entire world in every now. In "Genjōkōan" (1233), Dōgen offers an image that prevents this totality from becoming compression. Firewood becomes ash and does not become firewood again, yet one should not regard the ash as after and the firewood as before; firewood abides in its own dharma-position, which has its before and after, yet the before and after are cut off (*zengo saidan*) (Dōgen 2010 [1233; 1240]). Each moment is whole and distinct; it contains all time, yet does not absorb the others. Dōgen describes a *non-compressive totality*, in which every now is the whole and no now devours the rest. Ultimecia's compression is a demonic parody of *uji*: the totality of time achieved by making one now absorb all nows.

Nishida Kitarō's "self-determination of the eternal now" describes the eternal now not as a single moment but as the place (*basho*) in which moments arise and perish, a discontinuous continuity in which each instant is born and dies, held within a place of absolute nothingness (Nishida 1932; 2012 [1926]). Nishida's eternal now is topological rather than chronological: a place holds time without compressing it. This is the bridge to the promissory chronotope of Chapter Seven.

Nishitani Keiji's *Religion and Nothingness* (1961) distinguishes nihility, the abyss of meaninglessness that opens when the self takes itself as the center, from *śūnyatā*, emptiness, the field in which each thing is restored to its own home-ground, existing in itself and in all other things without center (Nishitani 1982 [1961]). Compression is nihility absolutized: all things gathered into one self-centered ego. The field of emptiness is its opposite: all things in their own places within a whole that has no owner. Kuki Shūzō's lectures at Pontigny in 1928 contrasted the Buddhist will to deliverance from the cycle of time with the ethic of willed recurrence he discerned in *bushidō*;

his later theory of contingency is taken up in Chapter Seven. The concepts of the Kyoto School, deployed here with the caution stated in the Introduction, converge upon a single point. There is a totality of time that does not compress it, and that totality is a place.



CHAPTER SIX

Griever

The Lion, the Final Adversary, and the Materialized Imagination

It dissolves, diffuses, dissipates, in order to recreate.

COLERIDGE, BIOGRAPHIA LITERARIA XIII

THE final dungeon disassembles the junctional subject piece by piece, and the final adversary is assembled from the hero's own imagination: to defeat Ultimecia, Squall must destroy the lion he invented to keep himself safe. This short chapter reads the castle at the end of time as level design in the service of dispossession, and the final battle as the externalization and destruction of a fantasy.

6.1 The Gate of Locks: Dispossession as Level Design

Ultimecia's castle, reached through compressed time, seals the party's fundamental capacities on entry: the commands for items, magic, Guardian Forces and drawing, special command abilities, Limit Breaks, the power to revive fallen companions, and the power to save. Each is restored only by defeating one of the castle's guardians, in an order the player chooses. The final dungeon is thus the systematic dispossession of the junctional subject and its reconstruction under hostile conditions: a self taken apart into its component capacities and reassembled one function at a time. If Chapter One showed that the junctional subject is a configuration rather than a history, the castle demonstrates the converse: strip the configuration away and nothing remains but a body that can strike. The sealing of the save is the deepest of these deprivations. For a time the player is denied the means of depositing a self that can be returned to, compression enacted at the level of the interface (Chapter Eight).

Kafka's *The Castle* (1926), whose surveyor never gains admittance to the authority that governs the village, and his parable "Before the Law" (1915), in which a man waits a lifetime before a door that was meant only for him, supply the literary analogues: the castle as the place where access itself is withheld. Ultimecia's castle reverses Kafka. Entry is easy; it is one's own capacities that are locked.

6.2 Griever: The Enemy Drawn from the Hero's Mind

Squall wears a ring engraved with a lion, which he has privately named Griever. In the final battle, Ultimecia reads his mind for the most powerful being he can imagine and materializes it as a Guardian Force: Griever. She fights first alone, then through Griever, then fused with it, and at last in a monstrous final form. The ultimate adversary is constructed from the hero's own fantasy.

The device has a distinguished genealogy in speculative fiction. In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the planetary ocean materializes "visitors" drawn from the memories of the scientists who study it, among them the protagonist's dead wife; Andrei Tarkovsky's adaptation (1972) made the materialized beloved its center, and his *Stalker* (1979) imagined a Room that grants not the wish one professes but the wish at one's core. *Silent Hill 2* (2001) builds a town whose monsters are its protagonist's guilt made flesh. Psychoanalysis supplies the mechanism: Freudian projection, in which an internal state is expelled and encountered as an external threat, and Lacan's ego-ideal, the image of perfection from whose vantage the subject wishes to be seen. Griever is Squall's ego-ideal, projected and turned against him.

The name decides the interpretation. Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguishes mourning, in which libido is gradually withdrawn from a lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated into the ego, so that the ego's self-reproaches are reproaches against the object and the lost object darkens the ego itself (Freud 1957 [1917]). Squall's lion is grief armored as strength: the melancholic incorporation of the lost mothers, Raine, Ellone and Edea, into an ideal of invulnerability, a lion who needs no one. When Ultimecia, whose original name evokes Artemisia of Caria, the archetypal mourner (4.6), fuses with Griever, grief meets grief. The final battle is a confrontation between two forms of mourning hardened into power: the hero's, armored as self-sufficiency, and the sorceress's, armored as sovereignty over time. Uematsu's title for the music that accompanies Griever, "Maybe I'm a Lion," supplies the decisive inflection. The lion is a hypothesis of the self in the conditional mood, not its fact.

6.3 The Alchemical Lion and the Coniunctio

In the alchemical tradition the lion figures the raw, devouring desire of matter; the green lion devouring the sun is a celebrated image of the *Rosarium philosophorum* (1550). Jung's *Mysterium Coniunctionis* reads the alchemical opus as a psychology of the union of opposites, Sol and Luna, king and queen, achieved through a death (*nigredo*) and a rebirth and culminating in the *rebis*, the double being in which the opposites are fused (Jung 1963 [1955–56]). Squall, the solar lion, and Rinoa, the lunar sorceress with whom he first dances to a waltz named for the moon, enact the alchemical pair, and their union requires the lion's death. But the alchemical terminus, the fusion of two in one body, is precisely what the game refuses (Chapter Seven). *Final Fantasy VIII* stages the *coniunctio* and stops short of the *rebis*. The Two remain Two.

The Narnian frame of the Introduction closes here. In Lewis, the lion's sacrificial death and return break the witch's frozen winter. In *Final Fantasy VIII*, the lion has been captured by the witch and turned against the hero, and time resumes only when the lion dies and does not return. Squall Leonhart, whose name recalls Richard the Lionheart, must kill his own heraldry. Nietzsche's lion, which can say "I will" but cannot create, gives way to the child (2.7).

6.4 The Imagination as Battlefield

Kant assigns the imagination (*Einbildungskraft*) two functions: the reproductive synthesis that holds the past within the present, and the productive or figurative synthesis that gives form to what is not given (A100–A102; B151–152). The game's adversaries attack this faculty twice. The Guardian Forces assault the reproductive imagination, erasing the reproducible manifold of a life (1.4). Ultimecia assaults the productive imagination, turning the hero's fantasy into his enemy. Coleridge distinguished fancy, which "has no other counters to play with, but fixities and definites," from the secondary imagination, which "dissolves, diffuses, dissipates, in order to recreate" (*Biographia Literaria*, ch. XIII). Griever is fancy: an assemblage of fixities, a lion composed from a ring. The dissolution of the world that follows his defeat, in which landscapes melt and Squall's identity disperses, is the secondary imagination dissolving in order to recreate.

What survives both assaults? Neither memory nor fantasy, the two products of the imagination, but something of another order: a promise, which neither reproduces a past nor produces an image, but binds a self to a place and to a person. The thesis turns now to that promise.

CHAPTER SEVEN

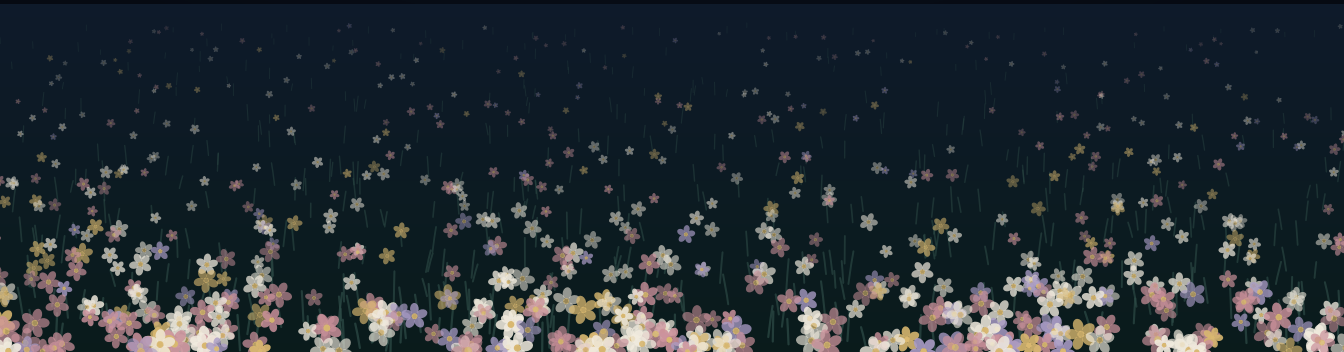
The Flower Field

Rendezvous Ontology, Deposited Ipseity, and the Promissory Chronotope

秘すれば花なり、秘せずは花なるべからず。

What is hidden is the flower; unhidden, it cannot be the flower.

ZEAMI, FŪSHIKADEN



THE flower field is the game's answer to its three dispossessions: a place where a promise holds a self that has lost its memory, its origin and its time, and where that self is restored not by recollection but by being found. This chapter reads the ending as a philosophical argument, assembles the materials from which rendezvous ontology is built, formalizes it in twelve propositions, and situates it within a family of works that share its problem.

7.1 The Ending as Philosophical Argument

After Ultimecia's defeat, the party is scattered through compressed time. Squall wanders alone through landscapes that dissolve as he crosses them; his inner voice fragments and drifts toward the registers of childhood; he tries to call Rinoa to mind and cannot see her face. He arrives at the orphanage in the past, witnesses the dying Ultimecia transfer her power to the young Edea, who accepts it so that no child will have to, and speaks the words that will found SeeD. Then, exhausted, he reaches the field of flowers near the orphanage, where he had promised Rinoa that he would wait for her so that she could find him, and collapses. Rinoa, searching, finds him; a feather falls, as it did at the beginning. The closing cinematic follows: camcorder footage of a celebration at the Garden; Seifer fishing with Fujin and Raijin; Laguna at Raine's grave with Kiros, Ward and Ellone; Cid and Edea together; and finally Squall and Rinoa on the balcony where they first watched a shooting star, where he smiles.

The sequence enacts the three dispossessions in turn and resolves none of them by restoration. Chronology is not restored by Squall's effort: he is carried out of compression by being found. Memory is not restored: he cannot recall her face, and the camcorder footage that closes the game supplies, as tertiary retention, the record his mind could not keep. Origin is not restored: the founding loop closes, and SeeD remains a fable without a first term. What resolves the sequence is a rendezvous. That is the game's philosophical argument, and the rest of this chapter makes it explicit.

7.2 Recollection Forward: Kierkegaard's Repetition and the Lover Who Abides

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) opens by opposing two movements. Repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward (Kierkegaard 1983 [1843]). Recollection is the Greek model of knowledge, Platonic anamnesis, in which learning is the remembering of what the soul knew before birth (*Meno* 81a–86c). Repetition is a model of existence, in which a self is gained by receiving again, forward, what it has given up. The Laguna dreams are recollection, the past repeated backward. The promise in the flower field is repetition, a recollection forward: a memory of the future, which remembers what has not yet happened.

Works of Love (1847) supplies the ethical figure. In the deliberation "Love Abides," Kierkegaard describes the lover who abides when the other has broken off the relationship. Where

the other would end the sentence with a period, the lover makes the break a dash; the sentence is not finished, and the one who abides waits at the point of rupture, for love hopes all things (Kierkegaard 1995 [1847]). Squall's promise to wait in the field is the abiding lover's dash. Gabriel Marcel's "creative fidelity" completes the figure: fidelity is not inert constancy but continual creation, sustained by availability (*disponibilité*) to the other and by a hope that refuses to treat the future as a mere extension of the present (Marcel 1964 [1940]; 1951 [1944]).

7.3 The Animal That Can Promise: Nietzsche, Arendt, Ricoeur

The second essay of Nietzsche's *Genealogy of Morality* opens with a question: is not the breeding of an animal with the right to make promises the paradoxical task nature has set itself with regard to the human being? Nietzsche treats forgetfulness not as inertia but as an active faculty of repression, a doorkeeper of psychic order without which there could be no happiness and no present; against it, the human being bred a memory of the will, a long chain of willing between the original "I will" and its discharge, so that it could vouch for itself as future (Nietzsche 2007 [1887], II.1). *Final Fantasy VIII* stages both faculties with uncanny exactness. The Guardian Forces are Nietzsche's active forgetting turned into an instrument; the promise is the memory of the will. The promise survives the forgetting because it is not stored where the Guardian Forces reside. It is not a representation of the past but a binding of the future.

Arendt's promise, which binds the unpredictability of the future (3.3), supplies the political frame; Paul Ricoeur supplies the theory of identity. *Oneself as Another* distinguishes two models of identity: *idem*, sameness, the permanence of character through time, and *ipse*, selfhood, whose paradigm is keeping one's word. Self-constancy in the promise does not require sameness; it is the manner in which a person conducts herself so that another can count on her, answering the other's "Where are you?" with "Here I am" (Ricoeur 1992 [1990]). Squall, having lost the *idem* of memory and image, retains *ipse* through the promise. But Ricoeur's *ipse* remains the self's own achievement, and the game adds the other's custody: the promise is kept *for* him by the one who comes to find him. The thesis calls this *deposited ipseity*, selfhood held in trust, like a deposit, by another who can return it. Ricoeur's dialogue gives the scene its grammar. Squall's waiting is a "Here I am" spoken without words; Rinoa's search is the question to which it answers.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) supplies the physics this ethics requires. Its protagonist, the physicist Shevek, seeks a general temporal theory uniting two accounts of time held to be incompatible: Sequency, time as succession, the arrow; and Simultaneity, time as a whole in which all moments coexist. The novel ties the theory to fidelity. Shevek reflects that fulfillment is a function of time, that the pursuit of pleasure is circular and atemporal and ends in a locked room, and that the bond he shares with his partner Takver, a promise kept across years of separation, is possible only because time binds past and future into a continuity that can be held (Le Guin 1974). Ultimecia's compression is pure Simultaneity, all moments made one and none succeeding another; the game's promise is Shevek's unity, a simultaneity of past and future borne by a sequence of days. Le Guin's anarchist world also has a word of reproach for the ego's claim on what it holds,

propertarian, which names the disposition that Time Compression carries to its limit: the will to own time itself.

Deposited ipseity has an inverted image in Nintendo's *The Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask* (2000), released the following year. A moon with a grimacing face will fall on the land of Termina in three days, drawn down by Skull Kid, a lonely creature abandoned by his friends and possessed by a cursed mask. The player survives by playing a song that returns the hero to the dawn of the first day; everything accomplished in the cycle is undone, and only the hero remembers. The townspeople forget, each time, that their troubles were ever resolved, and the player records those troubles in a notebook in order to resolve them again. The hero also takes on the faces of the dead: masks holding the spirits of a Deku child who died in the woods, a fallen Goron hero and a dying Zora musician, whose forms he assumes in order to finish what they left undone. *Majora's Mask* makes the player the depositary of everyone else's ipseity, keeping faith with people who will never remember that he did. *Final Fantasy VIII* gives that role to Rinoa and the forgetting to Squall. Both works hold that fidelity need not be remembered by its object to be real, and both set it against a falling moon.

7.4 The Aprosopic Rendezvous: Levinas, Orpheus, Izanagi, and the Unrecalled Face

For Levinas, the face of the other exceeds the idea of the other in me; it is not a representation but an expression, and its epiphany is an ethical command that breaks the totality in which I would comprehend the world (Levinas 1969 [1961]). In *Time and the Other*, the future is not my projection but the other, what comes toward me from outside (Levinas 1987 [1947]). Squall's inability to recall Rinoa's face in the dissolving world is the game's most philosophically charged image. Memory cannot hold the face. The face must come from outside, and it does: she finds him. The thesis calls this an *aprosopic rendezvous*, from the Greek *a-prosōpon*, "without a face." *Prosōpon* means face, but also mask and person, and its loss is the loss of a persona: what remains when the remembered image is gone is not an image but an advent.

The figure inverts the oldest myth of descent. Orpheus goes down to the underworld to bring Eurydice back and loses her by turning to look before they reach the light (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). Maurice Blanchot read the gaze of Orpheus as the desire to see Eurydice not in daylight but in her nocturnal essence, as she is in her absence (Blanchot 1982 [1955]). In *Final Fantasy VIII*, the one lost in the underworld cannot look, having lost her image, and the one who descends to find him does not turn back. The Japanese version of the myth is harsher: in the *Kojiki*, Izanagi looks upon the decaying Izanami against her prohibition, and the look severs life from death. The game's withholding of the face is a refusal of the Orphic look.

The motif radiates through the game and its comparanda. Esthar, the city hidden from the world by optical camouflage, bears a name that recalls Esther, whose book never names God and whom the rabbis connected with the verse "And I will surely hide my face in that day" (Deuteronomy 31:18; b. Ḥullin 139b). Paul de Man argued that prosopopoeia, the figure that gives a face to

the absent, defaces in the very act of conferring a face (de Man 1979). In Marker's *La Jetée*, the memory of a woman's face is the vehicle of time travel. In Satoshi Kon's *Millennium Actress* (2001), an actress pursues for a lifetime a man whose face she has forgotten, and confesses at last that what she loves is the pursuit itself. In Abe Kōbō's *The Face of Another* (1964), a man whose face has been destroyed builds a mask and with it a second self. *Final Fantasy VIII* differs from all of these. The face is neither the means of the rendezvous nor its substitute but its end: she finds him, and only then, in the closing cinematic, is her face given back.

Alfred Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958) is the modern form of the Orphic gaze, and the clearest picture of what the aprosopic rendezvous avoids. Scottie, a detective, falls in love with Madeleine, who seems to fall to her death from a mission bell tower. When he meets Judy, who resembles her, he remakes her, through clothes, hair and manner, into the image of the dead woman. He then discovers that Judy played Madeleine in Gavin Elster's scheme to disguise the murder of his wife as a suicide that Scottie would witness, and he forces her back up the tower, where she falls to her death. Love fixed on a remembered image destroys the living person who is made to match it. Chris Marker returned to *Vertigo* throughout his work: in *La Jetée*, the lovers stand before the cut trunk of a sequoia marked with the dates of history, an image taken from Hitchcock's film, and *Sans Soleil* revisits its San Francisco locations (Marker 1962; 1983). In *Final Fantasy VIII*, the image of the beloved is precisely what memory loses, and the loss is a mercy. Rinoa is not required to match anything Squall remembers. She arrives as herself.

7.5 The Scene of the Two: Badiou, Aristophanes, and the Refusal of Fusion

Alain Badiou defines love as the construction of a world from the point of view of the Two rather than the One: a truth procedure in which two persons experience the world through their difference, betrayed both by the romantic ideal of fusion and by the liberal fantasy of a love without risk (Badiou 2012 [2009]). Love begins in an encounter, an event, and continues as fidelity to that event (Badiou 2005 [1988]). Aristophanes' speech in Plato's *Symposium* is the founding text of the fusional ideal. Human beings were once double, until Zeus split them, and love is the longing of each half for its other; Hephaestus, Aristophanes imagines, might offer to weld the lovers into a single being, to live as one and die as one, remaining one even in Hades, and no lover would refuse (*Symposium* 189c–193d, esp. 192d–e).

Final Fantasy VIII refuses Hephaestus. Time Compression is Hephaestus's offer extended to time, every moment welded into one; *Evangelion*'s Instrumentality is the same offer extended to souls. Freud observed that Eros seeks to combine organic substances into ever larger unities (Freud 1961 [1930]); at its limit, unity becomes indistinguishable from the death drive's return to the inanimate. The love of Squall and Rinoa preserves the interval. Kuki Shūzō's *The Structure of Iki* (1930) gives the interval an aesthetic. *Iki*, an urban ideal of refined allure, is composed of *bitai*, a coquetry that approaches the other while keeping the relation a possibility; *ikiji*, pride or brio; and *akirame*, resigned detachment. Coquetry extinguishes itself in union; *iki* sustains possibility as

possibility (Kuki 2004 [1930]). The relation of Squall and Rinoa, perpetually approaching and never fused, has the tension Kuki called *iki*.

Two further works sharpen the contrast. Square's own *Xenogears* (1998), released a year before *Final Fantasy VIII* and steeped in Gnostic myth and in the vocabularies of Freud, Jung and Nietzsche, makes its lovers recur: Fei and Elly are the latest incarnations of a man and a woman whose love has repeated across ten thousand years. Its fidelity is cyclical, the same love returning through many lives; *Final Fantasy VIII*'s is promissory, one appointment kept within one life. Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) ends by affirming the fusion the game refuses, as its heroine merges with an artificial intelligence to become a new being. The game takes the other path: two who remain two.

David Mitchell's *Cloud Atlas* (2004) gives recurrence a sign on the body. Its six nested stories, running from a Pacific voyage in the nineteenth century to a future after civilization's collapse, are linked by a comet-shaped birthmark borne by a protagonist in each era, and by documents that pass forward, each story read or watched by the protagonist of the next. One of those stories is the testimony of Sonmi~451, a cloned server in the corporate state of Nea So Copros, who discovers that fabricants like her are killed at the end of their service and processed into the food fed to the next generation of fabricants, and who records her testimony before her execution. The comet links the novel to the game's shooting star, and the birthmark to the scars of 2.8: a recognition token written on the skin. But Mitchell's identity across time is a mark that recurs, whereas the game's is an appointment that is kept. A scar or a birthmark can be read by anyone; the flower field can be found only by the one to whom the promise was made.

7.6 The Penelopean Inversion: Odysseus's Bed and the Topology of Fidelity

In the fifth book of the *Odyssey*, Calypso offers Odysseus immortality and agelessness if he will remain with her; he chooses to return to his mortal wife, who will age and die. The refusal of the eternal for the temporal is the epic's founding choice, and Wim Wenders's *Wings of Desire* (1987) inverts its terms with an angel who renounces eternity for time, touch and love. Penelope's fidelity is figured as suspended time: she weaves a shroud by day and unravels it by night. Her final test of Odysseus is a place. She orders the marriage bed moved; Odysseus protests that it cannot be moved, since he built it himself around the trunk of a living olive tree, a secret known only to the two of them (*Odyssey* XXIII.177–204). The secret of fidelity is an immovable place.

The Homeric topology of fidelity is gendered: the woman abides at the immovable center, the man wanders and returns. *Final Fantasy VIII* inverts it. The knight abides in the flower field; the sorceress wanders through dissolving time and finds him. The inversion discloses the formal law of every rendezvous, which requires asymmetry, one fixed point and one seeker; *Millennium Actress* shows what follows when both parties move, an endless pursuit. The *Odyssey* also names fidelity's antagonist, which is forgetting. The Lotus-Eaters make men forget their homecoming (IX), and the Sirens' song lures sailors from the way home (XII). Among the first Guardian Forces Squall ac-

quires is Siren, named for the creature whose song undoes the memory of home. The game's amnesiac pharmakon is the epic's lotus.

Yoshimoto Banana's *Kitchen* (1988) supplies the most tender version of the seeker who crosses a distance to find the one who waits. Mikage, orphaned when her grandmother, her last relative, dies, is taken in by Yūichi and his mother Eriko, a transgender woman who raised him after his mother's death, and she finds in kitchens the one place where she can bear to exist. In the novella's second part, Eriko is murdered by a man who had fixated on her and turned violent on learning that she is transgender, and Yūichi withdraws into grief. Mikage, away for work, buys a bowl of katsudon late at night, takes a taxi across the dark to the inn where he is staying, and climbs in to bring it to him (Yoshimoto 1993 [1988]). The rendezvous is asymmetrical exactly as the game's is: one waits, lost; the other seeks and finds. John Whittier Treat read Yoshimoto's fiction as a nostalgia of the *shōjo*, the girl suspended between childhood and adulthood (Treat 1993), and *Kitchen* shares the game's orphaned, chosen family and its conviction that a place, a kitchen or a field, can hold a self that genealogy no longer holds.

7.7 Idyll, Basho, Heimat: The Promissory Chronotope

Bakhtin's idyllic chronotope (3.8) defines the flower field's form. Generations coexist in a single place: Edea young and old, Squall as child and as adult, Rinoa returning to the site of a promise. The unity of place softens the temporal boundaries between lives; time is folded by place rather than compressed. Nishida's *basho*, the place in which the eternal now determines itself (5.9), names the metaphysics of such a place: time held, not abolished. Watsuji's correction of Heidegger (2.9) names its anthropology: human existence is spatial as well as temporal, and the between of persons is a place. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* ends by naming the goal of history *Heimat*, homeland, which he describes as something that shines into everyone's childhood and in which no one has yet been (Bloch 1986 [1954–59]). The flower field is Blochian *Heimat*: a childhood place that is also a promised future, a not-yet that is remembered. Gaston Bachelard found in the childhood house the shelter of daydreaming, an oneiric house more durable than memory (Bachelard 1964 [1958]); the orphanage and its field are such a house. Even Heidegger, whose early analytic the game opposes, turned in his later work toward place, toward what Jeff Malpas has called the topology of being (Malpas 2006). The game's anti-Heideggerianism targets the Heidegger of *Being and Time* and converges with the late Heidegger of the field path.

Zeami's *Fūshikaden* distinguishes the "flower of the moment" (*jibun no hana*), the passing bloom of a young performer's charm, from the "true flower" (*makoto no hana*), which endures because it has been cultivated through discipline, and teaches that the flower which is hidden is the flower (Zeami 1984). The flower field is the place where the flower of the moment, an adolescent love beneath a shooting star, becomes the true flower, a fidelity that survives the dissolution of time. Two contrasting gardens clarify the stakes. Mishima Yukio's *The Decay of the Angel* (1970), the last novel of his tetralogy, ends in the garden of a convent whose abbess tells the aged Honda that she never knew the young man whose reincarnations he has followed across four books; Honda is left in a garden that holds no memories at all. Mishima's final garden is the garden of absolute

forgetting. T. S. Eliot's "Burnt Norton" opens with a meditation on time present and time past as perhaps both present in time future, and leads into a rose-garden where what might have been and what has been point to one end. *Final Fantasy VIII*'s garden is neither the garden of oblivion nor the garden of eternal presence. It is the garden of a promise.

The game's vocabulary prepares this garden from the start. Its institutions are Gardens, its graduates are SeeDs, and its strongest Guardian Force, drawn from a weapon kept in a research facility beneath the sea, is named Eden: the first garden, recovered as an instrument of war. The lexicon belongs to the history of pedagogy as much as to Genesis. Friedrich Fröbel, who coined the word *Kindergarten* in 1840, imagined the school as a garden in which children are cultivated like plants, and the horticultural metaphor runs through the German ideal of *Bildung*. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) ends its survey of the world's cruelties with the counsel *il faut cultiver notre jardin*, the garden as retreat from history; Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941) makes a garden the labyrinth of all possible times. *Final Fantasy VIII* moves from one kind of garden to another. The Garden cultivates children for war, under a hidden purpose, in an economy of rank and salary; the flower field is uncultivated, grown by no institution and owned by no one, and what blooms there is not a soldier but a promise. The movement of the whole game is from the Garden to the field: from cultivation to blossoming.

The oldest science-fictional journey to the end of time ends with flowers. In H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895), the Time Traveller reaches the year 802,701, where humanity has divided into the leisured, childlike Eloi and the subterranean Morlocks, who tend the machinery below and feed on the Eloi above: Wells's allegory of class division carried into biology. He travels on to a terminal beach millions of years later under a swollen red sun, where life is dwindling into silence, the far-future desolation of which Ultimecia's castle is a descendant. He returns with nothing to prove his journey but two flowers that Weena, the Eloi girl he befriended and lost, had put in his pocket. The narrator keeps them, shrivelled and brittle, as witness, in Wells's closing words, "that even when mind and strength had gone, gratitude and a mutual tenderness still lived on in the heart of man." The game's ending answers Wells across a century. At the end of time, what remains is not memory or strength but a tenderness that cannot be converted into either, and in both works its emblem is a flower.

The thesis can now define its term. A *promissory chronotope* is a place in which a promise binds future to past by binding both to a location, so that temporal boundaries soften, as in the idyll, without collapsing, as in compression. It differs from Mircea Eliade's sacred time, the *illud tempus* of origins periodically regenerated by ritual return (Eliade 1954 [1949]), because it is not a return to an origin but an appointment with a future. It is constituted not by recurrence but by fidelity.

Alain Resnais and Marguerite Duras's *Hiroshima mon amour* (1959) gives the promissory chronotope its darkest counterpart. A French actress, in Hiroshima to make a film about peace, spends a night with a Japanese architect, in a city where the atomic bomb dropped by the United States on 6 August 1945 had killed some 140,000 people by the end of that year. Through him she recalls her first love, a German soldier in occupied Nevers who was shot dead on the day the town was liberated; afterwards townspeople shaved her head in public, as was done to thousands of

French women accused of relations with German soldiers, and her family shut her in a cellar. The film is built on the double bind the Guardian Forces impose: to remember is to be destroyed by grief, and to forget is to betray, and she is horrified to find that she is forgetting. At its close the lovers name each other after their cities, she calling him Hiroshima and he calling her Nevers. Identity has become place, as in the promissory chronotope, but the places are sites of catastrophe and the identity they confer is a wound. *Final Fantasy VIII* makes the same transfer from person to place, and chooses a field of flowers rather than a ruined city, a promise rather than a scar.

7.8 Kuki's Encounter: From Contingency to Appointment

Kuki's *The Problem of Contingency* (1935) analyzes contingency in its logical, empirical and metaphysical forms and locates its core in the encounter of two independent elements, the meeting of a dyad: the contingent is what happens when two things, each with its own causal series, chance to meet. Kuki closes with an ethical turn, citing a Pure Land verse to the effect that none who meet it pass by in vain. The task of existence is to internalize the contingent encounter, making what happened by chance into a destiny by refusing to let the meeting pass in vain (Kuki 1935).

The game's love story is built on this structure. Its first encounter is contingency: at the graduation ball, Rinoa picks Squall out of the crowd, and a shooting star crosses the sky. Its last is appointment: the meeting in the flower field, promised in advance and kept. Between them lies the conversion of contingency into fidelity, the second encounter as chance repeated as choice. Kuki's ethics of the encounter and Badiou's fidelity to the event converge here. The game's systems offer an exact counter-image. The Guardian Force Diablos, sealed in a lamp the headmaster gives to Squall, teaches an ability, Enc-None, that eliminates random encounters altogether. The player can abolish contingency, the very defense Squall practices in the first half of the game, rendered as a menu option. The ending restores the encounter as the ground of being.

7.9 Fabulous Retroactivity and the Puncture of the Loop

The founding loop closes at the orphanage. Squall speaks to Edea of SeeD and the Garden, and the institution that made him is founded on his words. But the rendezvous happens after the loop closes and outside it. The loop determines SeeD and the succession of witches; it does not determine the meeting in the field. The rendezvous is a point of excess within a closed causal structure, not a break in causality but a surplus the structure cannot account for. The thesis calls this the *puncture* of the loop.

Nietzsche's thought of eternal recurrence, introduced in *The Gay Science* as a demon's question whether one would will one's life again, innumerable times, in every detail (Nietzsche 2001 [1882], §341), illuminates Squall's act at the orphanage. In founding the institution that will produce his own orphanhood, abandonment and war, he wills his entire past: *amor fati*. Zarathustra's vision of the gateway called "Moment," where two eternal paths meet, one running back and one running forward (Nietzsche 2006 [1883–85], III, "On the Vision and the Riddle"), describes the flower field, where the path back to the orphanage and the path forward to the promised meeting

converge. Yet the game completes *amor fati* with the love of a particular other. The affirmation of the loop becomes bearable because the loop contains the field. In Hegelian terms, the circle of origin becomes a true infinite only when it includes the other that exceeds it. Derrida's fabulous retroactivity founds the institution; the rendezvous inhabits what the fable founded.

7.10 Rendezvous Ontology: Twelve Propositions

1. **The self is not the bearer of its memories but the addressee of a promise.** What persists through mnemonic dispossession is not a content but an address: someone is still expected somewhere.
2. **A promise is recollection forward, and it binds not a time but a place.** Dates fail under compression; places do not. The promise is kept by being somewhere.
3. **Under mnemonic dispossession, ipseity survives as deposit.** Selfhood is held in trust by another who can return it by finding the self.
4. **The face of the other cannot be stored; it arrives.** The rendezvous is aprosopic in expectation and prosopic in fulfillment.
5. **Every rendezvous is asymmetric: one abides, one seeks.** Fidelity is a topology, not a symmetry, and the abiding party need not be the one tradition assigns.
6. **The place of the rendezvous is a promissory chronotope.** In it temporal boundaries soften without collapsing, and generations coexist without fusing.
7. **The promise is the inconvertible remainder.** It cannot be drawn, stocked, refined, junctioned or exchanged, and it is therefore the one value the general economy of convertibility cannot capture.
8. **Compression abolishes the delay that gives time; the rendezvous restores it.** Love is *différance* kept.
9. **The rendezvous converts contingency into appointment without abolishing contingency.** The first encounter remains chance; the second is fidelity.
10. **A loop without origin is punctured, not broken, by the rendezvous.** What is founded by fable is inhabited by fidelity.
11. **The rendezvous is the Scene of the Two.** It refuses fusion in space, as in Instrumentality, and in time, as in Compression.
12. **Rendez-vous: render yourselves.** The self is what is given back at an appointed place.

7.11 Rendez-vous: An Etymological Coda and a Comparative Family

The French *rendez-vous* is the imperative plural of the reflexive *se rendre*, "to betake oneself," literally "render yourselves" or "present yourselves"; it entered use in the sixteenth century as a military term for the place appointed for the assembly of troops. The mercenary vocabulary of SeeD thus returns transfigured at the end: the soldiers' assembly point becomes the lovers' appointed place. And the verb's sense of restitution, *rendre*, to give back, names what the flower field accomplishes. The self is what is rendered, given back, at an appointed place.

The rendezvous has a family. In Audrey Niffenegger's *The Time Traveler's Wife* (2003), Clare first meets the time-traveling Henry as a child in a meadow behind her family's house, where he returns again and again across her life and where she waits for him. In Philip Pullman's *The Amber Spyglass* (2000), Lyra and Will, condemned to live in separate worlds, promise to sit at noon every Midsummer's Day on a bench in the Oxford Botanic Garden that exists in both, so as to be near each other across the divide. In Michel Gondry and Charlie Kaufman's *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004), two lovers erase their memories of each other, yet the fragment of an invitation to meet at Montauk survives the erasure and brings them together again; the title comes from Pope's "Eloisa to Abelard" (1717), whose heroine envies the forgetful vestal her "Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind!" In Shinkai Makoto's *Your Name* (2016), two young people who have exchanged bodies across time forget each other's names and meet at last on a stairway, while a grandmother teaches that the braided cord is time itself. In Hosoda Mamoru's *The Girl Who Leapt Through Time* (2006), a boy from the future promises to wait there, and the girl promises to run to him. In Miyazaki Hayao's *Howl's Moving Castle* (2004), Sophie, glimpsing Howl's childhood, calls out to him to find her in the future. *Serial Experiments Lain* (1998) makes existence a matter of being remembered by others. Alain Resnais and Alain Robbe-Grillet's *Last Year at Marienbad* (1961) turns on a man's insistence that a woman promised, a year before, to meet him, a promise she does not remember, amid the geometric hedges of a formal garden. Its frequently cited forerunner, Adolfo Bioy Casares's *The Invention of Morel* (1940), imagines a machine that records a week of life and replays it forever, and a narrator who records himself beside the woman he loves so as to share her eternity: the compressive alternative, love as frozen replay.

Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Buried Giant* (2015) sets its love story inside a political amnesia. A mist breathed by the she-dragon Querig, enchanted by Merlin at Arthur's command, makes Britons and Saxons forget that Arthur's forces, breaking a peace he had himself brokered, massacred the women, children and elderly of Saxon villages; when the Saxon warrior Wistan kills the dragon, memory returns, and with it the certainty of renewed war. Through this mist an elderly couple travels toward a boatman who will ferry a couple to his island together only if their love is true, and their love is tested as their memories, including memories of wrongs between them, return. Ishiguro poses the question the Guardian Forces pose: whether a peace bought with forgetting is a peace, and whether a love can survive the return of what it forgot.

These works compose a family. *Final Fantasy VIII* is distinguished within it by integrating the rendezvous into a systemic critique of convertibility, so that the promise appears not as a romantic motif but as the inconvertible remainder of an entire economy.



CHAPTER EIGHT

The Save Point

Ludic Temporality, Vernacular Hermeneutics, and the Medium as Rendezvous

Werd ich zum Augenblicke sagen: Verweile doch! du bist so schön!

Should I ever say to the moment: Stay, you are so beautiful!

GOETHE, FAUST I, 1699–1700

THE medium repeats the game's argument: the save point is a rendezvous between a player and her future self, the player is an Ellone who projects consciousness into a past she cannot change, and the fan theories are attempts to close the dispossessions the game keeps open. This chapter turns rendezvous ontology back upon play, counter-play, reception and return.

8.1 The Save Point as Rendezvous

Save points in *Final Fantasy VIII* are luminous sites distributed through the world at which the state of play may be recorded. José Zagal and Michael Mateas distinguish the temporal frames of play, namely real-world time, gameworld time, coordination time and fictive time, and show how games couple and decouple them (Zagal and Mateas 2010); Jesper Juul describes games as "half-real," real rules joined to fictional worlds (Juul 2005); Christopher Hanson analyzes the temporal affordances specific to the medium, saving and replay among them (Hanson 2018). The save point belongs to all these frames at once. To save is to deposit a self, a configuration of junctions, a stage of the plot and a position in the world, at a place, so that a future self may return to it. The save point is a rendezvous between the player's present and future selves, and the save file is deposited ipseity at the level of the medium: a self held in trust by the machine, recoverable by being found.

The castle's sealing of the save (6.1) is compression at the level of the interface: for a time no deposit is possible, and the player's future self has nowhere to meet her. The flower field is the narrative's ultimate save point, the place where a self is deposited and recovered; the save point is the medium's flower field. Later games made the structure explicit. In Toby Fox's *Undertale* (2015), certain characters remember the player's resets and reloads, so that saving becomes a diegetic fact with moral weight. In *Nier: Automata* (2017), the final ending invites the player to delete her own save data in order to help unknown players elsewhere: the save as gift, in Mauss's and Derrida's sense, the deposited self given away so that others may be found.

Watanabe Shin'ichirō's *Cowboy Bebop* (1998) supplies the closest precursor to the camcorder that closes *Final Fantasy VIII*. Faye Valentine was frozen in cryogenic sleep for decades after an accident and woke with no memory of her life. In the episode "Speak Like a Child," she receives a videotape she recorded as a girl, in which her younger self cheers on the person she will become: a self deposited in a recording and found by a self who cannot remember making it. Later, when her memories return, she goes back to her childhood home, finds it in ruins, and lies down on the ground where her bed once stood. The series offers the two halves of rendezvous ontology separately and without consolation: the past self keeps its appointment only through a machine, and the place survives only as ruin. *Final Fantasy VIII* joins the halves, a recording that supplies what memory lost and a place that still holds a person who can find you.

8.2 The Player as Ellone

The player projects consciousness into a fictional being whose story has already been written, experiences that being's life as present, and cannot change what has been authored, only perform it. This is Ellone's gift and Ellone's lesson. The console is a Junction Machine. Squall's parenthetical thoughts, addressed to no one within the fiction, are addressed to the player outside it: the player is the guest-consciousness in Squall as Squall was in Laguna, so that junctioned focalization (3.2) is doubled at the level of the medium. Ricoeur's third moment of mimesis, refiguration, in which a configured narrative is completed in the world of its reader (Ricoeur 1984–88 [1983–85]), names the act by which the player keeps the text's appointment. Borges's dreamer who discovers that he too is dreamed (3.1) completes the regress. The player dreams Squall, who dreams Laguna, and the game invites the suspicion that the player too is expected somewhere.

The junction of player and character has a single emblem. Squall's gunblade couples the archaic weapon of the knight with the modern weapon of the soldier, a blade fitted with a revolver's mechanism, and its mechanic completes the coupling: when the player presses a trigger at the instant a strike lands, the attack is intensified. The weapon is finished only by the player's timing. At the moment of the cut, character and player are junctioned, and the knight's blade, like the knight himself, is half someone else's.

8.3 Counter-Play: Low-Level Runs, Card Economies, and Critical-HP Dwelling

The game's community has developed practices that push its systems to their limits, and each discloses the system's philosophy with unusual clarity. In the low-level challenge, players exploit level scaling by avoiding experience altogether, suppressing random encounters with Enc-None, defeating enemies by means that yield no experience, and building power entirely through refinement and junction, so that the game is completed by characters of minimal level against correspondingly weak opponents. The practice is an ascesis of non-accumulation, the anti-Bildung of the rules (1.7) carried to its logical end. Card economies exploit Triple Triad and Card Mod to acquire endgame magic within the first hours, converting a minigame into capital: the player as speculator in the general economy of convertibility. And because Limit Breaks become available when a character's hit points fall into a critical band, players deliberately keep characters near death, or under Aura, to access them continuously. Critical-HP dwelling is a parody of Heideggerian authenticity: being-toward-death as exploit, proximity to death as a resource to be managed.

Alexander Galloway's concept of countergaming (Galloway 2006), Miguel Sicart's account of the player as an ethical agent who interprets and resists a game's values (Sicart 2009), Roger Caillois's distinction between free improvisation (*paidia*) and rule-bound play (*ludus*) (Caillois 1961 [1958]), and Johan Huizinga's magic circle (Huizinga 1949 [1938]) frame these practices. They do not betray the game; they read it. Counter-play does for the systems what fan theory does for the story: it drives them to their limits and so renders their assumptions visible.

8.4 Three Theories, Three Dispossessions: A Structural Account of Fan Hermeneutics

Iser's account of the reader filling a text's blanks (Iser 1978 [1976]), Stanley Fish's interpretive communities (Fish 1980) and Henry Jenkins's description of fans as "textual poachers" who appropriate and rework the texts they love (Jenkins 1992) supply the framework for the game's extraordinary culture of hypothesis. Ricoeur's distinction between a hermeneutics of suspicion and a hermeneutics of faith (Ricoeur 1970 [1965]) is apt, since the major theories are suspicious readings that seek a hidden truth beneath the manifest story. This thesis proposes a structural account: each of the three canonical theories attempts to close one of the three dispossessions.

The first hypothesis holds that Squall dies from the ice shard Edea drives into him at the parade at the end of the first disc, and that everything thereafter is a dying dream. Its proponents point to the shift in tone that follows, the escalating improbability of the plot and the dreamlike imagery of the ending. The hypothesis is unsupported by the text and has never been endorsed by its makers, but it is symptomatic. It responds to chronological dispossession by supplying the closure of death, giving the dissolving chronology a terminus, in the manner of Heidegger's being-toward-death and of what Kermode called the sense of an ending, the need for fictions that confer meaning on time by concluding it (Kermode 1967).

The second hypothesis holds that Rinoa becomes Ultimecia. Its evidence is iconographic and structural: the wings, the inheritance of sorcery, Ultimecia's access to Griever, the logic of the loop. It has never been confirmed. It responds to genealogical dispossession by locating an origin, giving the loop of sorcery a first term in the beloved and uniting the angel and the madwoman in a single woman (4.4). As Chapter Four argued, it is structurally true even if empirically false: Ultimecia is what any sorceress becomes if the witch-loop is not broken.

The third hypothesis, that Laguna is Squall's father, is the most widely accepted. It is implied by chronology, by Raine's death, by Squall's age and by visual rhyme, and never pronounced. It responds to mnemonic dispossession by restoring the Name-of-the-Father, the symbolic anchor of identity the amnesiac orphans lack (3.6). It is the most persuasive theory because the text nearly states it, and the most revealing because the text does not.

Each theory, then, offers a closure: death, origin, father. Rendezvous ontology describes what the game offers instead: the dispossessions kept open but made habitable, a self that survives without death's closure, origin's ground or the father's name, because it is held by an appointment. Fan theory is vernacular philosophy, and also the community's own junction with the text: a collective attempt to hold, for one another, a meaning no single player could keep.

8.5 Reflective Nostalgia and the Remaster

Svetlana Boym distinguished restorative nostalgia, which seeks to reconstruct the lost home and presents itself as truth and tradition, from reflective nostalgia, which dwells in longing itself, ironic, inconclusive and aware that what it mourns cannot be retrieved (Boym 2001). The Remastered edition of 2019 returned the game to players who had first encountered it as adolescents two decades earlier: a rendezvous with one's own past self. Its optional conveniences, accelerated play and the suppression of random encounters among them, are, with an irony its makers may not have intended, technologies of compression and of Enc-None offered to the returning player. One may now compress the game itself. Whether the return is restorative or reflective depends on what the player does with the speed. Mark Fisher's hauntology (Fisher 2014) describes the return of 1999 as the return of a lost future; Bloch's *Heimat* (7.7) describes what the reflective return finds, a childhood place in which no one has yet been. The flower field, revisited by an adult, is the chronotope of reflective nostalgia.

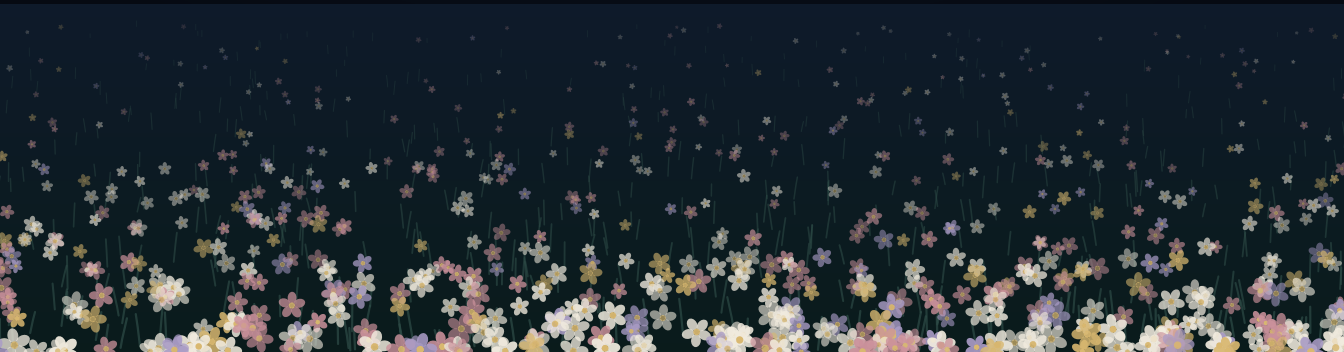


CONCLUSION

Rendez-vous

For, lo, the winter is past, the rain is over and gone; the flowers appear on the earth.

SONG OF SONGS 2:11–12, AUTHORIZED VERSION



Final Fantasy VIII argues, through its systems and its story together, that a self survives the loss of memory, origin and time only as an appointment kept with another at a place; this thesis has called that argument rendezvous ontology. The game converts memory into power through the Guardian Forces, origin into a loop through the founding of SeeD and the succession of witches, and time into a single instant through Ultimecia's compression. Beneath these conversions runs a general economy of convertibility in which magic, cards, experience, persons and time are exchangeable. What that economy cannot convert is the promise made at a place, which binds future to past, holds a self in trust for another, and restores that self not by recollection but by being found.

The thesis claims six contributions. To scholarship on *Final Fantasy* and the Japanese roleplaying game, it offers a sustained philosophical reading of the eighth entry that recovers its alleged flaws (exploitable junctions, level scaling, a disintegrating final act) as the procedural and narrative articulation of its thought. To game studies, it offers a ludo-hermeneutic method that reads rules as arguments, a concept, the general economy of convertibility, applicable to progression systems generally, and an account of the save point as rendezvous. To the philosophy of personal identity, it offers *deposited ipseity*, a fifth paradigm beside memory, narrative, decision and fusion, in which selfhood is held in trust by another. To the philosophy of time, it offers the *promissory chronotope*, the distinction between sovereign compression and messianic contraction, and a dialogue between the non-compressive totalities of Dōgen and Nishida and the critiques of presence in Benjamin and Derrida. To feminist criticism, it offers the *witch-loop*, in which persecution manufactures the witch, and the *Penelopean inversion*, in which the knight abides and the sorceress seeks. To Japanese studies, it offers a reading of late-1990s Japan, from the moratorium and the frustration of *amae* to millenarianism and the employment ice age, through a popular text, together with a case for *Final Fantasy VIII* as a precursor of *sekai-kei* that supplies the genre's missing third term, the place.

The limitations are real. The thesis reads the English localization and paraphrases it; a reading grounded in the Japanese script would refine many points. It makes no claim about the developers' intentions beyond what is general and well established. Its density invites the objection that a sufficiently large text will yield any pattern a sufficiently learned reader seeks. The defense is structural: the convergences identified here recur across independent registers (rules, dialogue, cinematics, music, onomastics) and cohere into a single argument rather than scattering into isolated resemblances. The distinction between genealogy, homology and instrumentality has been maintained throughout so that each claim can be weighed at its proper strength.

Several lines of inquiry follow. *Final Fantasy IX*, directed by Ito, meditates on mortality and the meaning of a life that ends; *Final Fantasy X*, written by Nojima under Kitase's direction, makes its protagonist a dream that must end; the *Kingdom Hearts* series pursues memory and its manipulation across many works. *Chrono Cross*, released by the same company in the same year, deserves a companion study as the other 1999 Square game in which time is threatened by a devouring feminine power. And the procedural rhetoric of level scaling, read here as an anti-Bildung, invites comparison across genres.

The game's final image is not a battle but a balcony. Squall and Rinoa stand where they first watched a shooting star, at night, under the moon, and Squall, who has spoken in parentheses for the length of the game, smiles. What has been restored is not his memory, which the Guardian Forces took and a camcorder had to supply; not his origin, which remains a quotation; and not time in the form in which Ultimecia would have possessed it, but time as something given, a delay held open between a promise and its keeping. Against compression, the game sets neither memory nor resolve but a field and a promise. The only time that cannot be compressed is the time one gives another by promising to be found.

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Keywords

Final Fantasy VIII · Square · Yoshinori Kitase · Kazushige Nojima · Hiroyuki Ito · Japanese role-playing games · game studies · ludo-hermeneutics · procedural rhetoric · rendezvous ontology · deposited ipseity · promissory chronotope · aprosopic rendezvous · general economy of convertibility · junctional subject · Epimethean institution · witch-loop · compressive sovereignty · inconvertible remainder · Time Compression · philosophy of time · bootstrap paradox · closed timelike curves · fabulous retroactivity · *pharmakon* · tertiary retention · memory and forgetting · personal identity · narrative identity · promise · fidelity · the face · the Scene of the Two · chronotope · idyll · *basho* · being-time (*uji*) · messianic time · *kairos* · hauntology · transgenerational inheritance · *mugen nō* · *amae* · psychosocial moratorium · *hikikomori* · *sekai-kei* · database consumption · standing-reserve · simulacra · level scaling · save points · counter-play · fan hermeneutics · reflective nostalgia · sorcery and gender · the angel in the house · courtly love · Kyoto School · Kuki Shūzō · Watsuji Tetsurō · Walter Benjamin · Jacques Derrida · Søren Kierkegaard · Emmanuel Levinas · Alain Badiou · Bernard Stiegler

Set in EB Garamond, Cormorant Garamond and Cinzel, with Sawarabi Mincho for Japanese.
Trim 7 × 10 in. The moon on each chapter opening waxes from new to full.


rendez-vous
The only time that cannot be compressed is the time one gives another by promising to be found.